

THE ART OF WORDS

Nazm

نظم

Persian · Urdu · Arabic Literary Rhetoric
Cross-referenced with Western Poetry and Music

Based on Hanjaar-e Goftar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939)
& Bahar-e Adab journal (2013)

Three Words That Measure Everything

معانی • بیان • بدیع

Ma'ani, Bayan, Badi'. The framework Persian literary theory runs on, and what it actually means when you strip the jargon away.

If you wanted to teach someone to write beautifully, you could say "write beautifully" and hope for the best. Or you could break it down. Persian and Arabic scholars, starting around the 9th century, chose the second option, and went very, very deep.

They split the whole science of eloquent writing into three branches. Together, these are called 'Ulūm al-Balāgha, the Sciences of Rhetoric. Nasrollah Taqavi's *Hanjaar-e Goftar* (The Art of Speech, 1939) organizes its 350 pages entirely around this three-part framework. Every rule, every example, every device maps to one of them.

Once you see the map, you realize English teachers have been talking about the same three things the whole time, they just never gave them this clean a set of names.

Science One: Ma'ani, What Is Your Sentence Actually Doing?

Ma'ani (علم معانی) means "meanings." It studies how the structure of a sentence, not just the words, shapes what it does to the reader. The same information can be delivered as a command, a question, a suggestion, or a statement, and each of those choices produces a different effect. Ma'ani is the study of those choices.

"Can you pass the salt?" is technically a yes/no question. Everyone knows it means "please pass the salt." Ma'ani is the science of that gap, between what a sentence looks like on the surface and what it's actually doing. It covers things like:

- Ijaz va Itnab, knowing when to be brief vs. when to develop an idea (knowing when to shut up, basically)
- Taqdim va Ta'khir, word order, and how moving things around shifts emphasis
- Maqam, register; speaking appropriately for the occasion and audience
- Khabar va Insha, the difference between making a statement and issuing a command or question

□□ MA'ANI IN ACTION, HAFEZ

"الا يا ايها الساقى ادر كاسا و ناولها
 كه عشق آسان نمود اول ولى افتاد مشكلها
 به بوى ناهى كاخر صبا زان طره بگشايد
 ز تاب جعد مشكينش چه خون افتاد در دلها"

"Come, cupbearer, pour the cup and pass it round / For love seemed easy at first, but then difficulties fell. / In hope that the dawn breeze might finally open that curl / Oh, what blood has fallen in hearts from those dark twisting locks.", An imperative opening sentence. Not a request, a command. The form carries urgency, desire, and the whole weight of what follows. That's Ma'ani: the sentence structure is doing emotional work.

□ MA'ANI IN ACTION, SHAKESPEARE

*"To be, or not to be, that is the question:
 Whether 'tis nobler in the mind to suffer
 The slings and arrows of outrageous fortune,
 Or to take arms against a sea of troubles"*

Hamlet, Act III. A question that isn't really a question, it's opening a void. The interrogative structure does philosophical and emotional work that a statement couldn't. Persian Ma'ani scholars would have a field day with this: a question used as an existential declaration.

Science Two: Bayan, How Did You Paint That?

Bayan (علم بيان) means "expression." This is the science of figurative language, how to say one thing by talking about something else. This is the most

recognizable branch to anyone who's been through high school English: simile, metaphor, metonymy, allusion. All four live here.

Tashbih, تشبيه *Simile*

Comparing A to B. "Her face is like the moon." 14+ sub-types. Full page →

Isti'ara, استعاره *Metaphor*

Remove the comparison word. "Her face IS the moon." Bigger claim, bigger effect. Full page →

Majaz, مجاز *Metonymy*

One word stands in for its neighbor through a real relationship. The crown for the king. Full page →

Kinaya, کنایه *Allusion / Double meaning*

Saying something literally true while meaning something else entirely. Hafez's whole wine situation. Full page →

ز کوی یار می آید نسیم باد نوروزی"
از این باد ار مدد خواهی چراغ دل فروزی
چه مستی است ندانم که رو به ما آورد
"که بوی باده از هر سوی می وزد از صبا

Hafez, "From the street of the Beloved comes the New Year breeze / From this wind, if you seek help, the candle of the heart lights. / What intoxication this is, I don't know, that comes toward us, / The scent of wine blows from every direction on the morning breeze." Every image in this couplet comes from Bayan's toolkit: the breeze as a divine messenger (metaphor), the heart as a candle (metaphor), the New Year wind as spiritual renewal (extended metaphor). Four lines, the whole system in use.

Science Three: Badi', The Part That Makes You Remember It

Badi' (علم بديع) means "innovative" or "beautiful." If Ma'ani is the architecture and Bayan is the view, Badi' is the detail work, the layer of craft that makes a line stay in your head. It covers two categories: devices that work through sound, and devices that work through meaning.

Badi' Lafzi, Sound Devices

Tajnis (pun, two words that sound the same, mean different things), Saj' (rhymed prose, rhythm and rhyme used in non-poetry writing), Radd al-Ajz (repeating the opening word at a line's end). These are what you feel before you understand them.

Badi' Ma'nawi, Meaning Devices

Tibaq (antithesis, pairing opposites so they charge each other), Mura'at al-Nazir (using words from the same semantic family, putting "sword," "shield," "blood," and "warrior" in one poem because they all belong together), Husn-e Ta'lil (giving a beautiful, poetic reason for something instead of the real one).

□ BADI', MIRZA GHALIB (URDU)

"زاروں خواہشیں ایسی کں کہ خواہشیں بے دم نکلا

بے مت نکلا میرا ارمان لیکن پھر بھی کم نکلا
نکالنا بھی تمہیں یاد آ گیا آخر کار
ملا تھا تم تو اس طرح کں دل لگا بیٹھا

"Thousands of desires, each worthy of dying for / Many were fulfilled, yet I wish for more / You finally remembered to send me away, / You had met me in such a way that my heart became attached." The antithesis of "many/yet still few" and the wordplay on dying-for-desire are Badi' working at full strength. The final couplet turns the screw: the very attachment is a wound.

□ BADI', SHAKESPEARE

"Ask for me tomorrow, and you shall find me a grave man."

Mercutio, Romeo and Juliet, Act III — delivered while dying. "Grave" means both solemn and a grave in the ground, two meanings, one sound, both active simultaneously. Persian Badi' scholars called this tajnis-e tamm, perfect pun. Ghalib would have appreciated the economy: one word, two meanings, and the joke lands hardest because the speaker doesn't survive it. That's Badi' working at its most concentrated.

Why Three? Why Not Just "Good Writing"?

The three-science framework lets you diagnose what kind of problem a piece of writing has. A sentence can be structurally sound (good Ma'ani) but use clumsy imagery (weak Bayan). A ghazal can have brilliant metaphors (strong Bayan) but feel musically flat (weak Badi'). The framework gives you precision. You're not just saying "something's off", you're saying exactly what's off.

Western rhetoric had the same instinct. Cicero divided good speaking into: finding ideas (inventio), arranging them (dispositio), expressing them beautifully (elocutio), memorizing them (memoria), and delivering them (pronuntiatio). Different categories, same impulse: break down what makes language work so you can study it, teach it, and do it better.

One-line version: Ma'ani is what your sentence is doing. Bayan is how you painted the idea. Badi' is the extra sparkle that makes it stick. All three are in

every great poem. The difference between traditions is how obsessively each one is named, sorted, and debated.

Based on Hanjaar-e Gofar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939) & Bahar-e Adab journal (2013).

She's Like the Moon (14 Ways)

(Tashbih) تشبيه

Persian scholars spent a thousand years categorizing every possible type of comparison. English class stops at two. Here's what they found, and why it matters.

You know what a simile is. You compare one thing to another because they share a quality. "Her voice is like honey." "His laugh sounds like a broken drain." You've had this since primary school.

Now imagine spending a thousand years asking: what kind of comparison is it? Is the shared quality stated or hidden? Is the comparison equal, or does one side obviously win? What happens when you build a comparison and then immediately flip it on yourself? What if the thing you're comparing to turns out to be worse than the thing you're describing?

That obsession is the history of Tashbih (تشبيه). The Bahar-e Adab study we're drawing on traces it across a thousand years: early medieval texts recognized a handful of types; by the 14th century, scholars had named over a dozen, and the list kept expanding because poets kept doing new things that the existing vocabulary couldn't describe.

The Four Parts of Any Comparison

Persian scholars gave every piece of a simile a precise name. Once you know these four, you can see exactly how any comparison is built, and understand why some hit harder than others.

Mushabba, مشبّه *The subject*

"Her face...", whatever you're comparing FROM. The thing being described.

Mushabba Bihi, مشبّه به *The standard*

"...like the moon." What you're comparing it TO. The reference point.

Adat, ادات *The particle*

"Like," "as," "resembles." In Persian: مانند، چون، همچو. The word that signals a comparison is happening.

Wajh-e Shabe, وجه شبه *The ground*

The shared quality, brightness, softness, distance. Often left unstated. Its absence is where the power lives.

In 1936, the English critic I.A. Richards named the same three parts: tenor, vehicle, and ground. Persian scholars had their version a thousand years earlier. Same insight, different clock.

The Types, Each One Does Something Different

Tashbih-e Mujmal, Leave the Reason Out

The most powerful similes often leave the shared quality unstated. "Her cheeks are like roses", you don't explain the redness or the softness or the perishability. You let the reader feel their way there. The act of finding the connection is what makes it stick.

□ OPEN-ENDED, RUMI

"بشنو این نی چون شکایت می‌کند
از جدایی‌ها حکایت می‌کند
کز نیستان تا مرا ببریده‌اند
از نفیرم مرد و زن نالیده‌اند"

"Listen to this reed, how it complains /
From separations it tells its tales / Since
they cut me from the reed bed / Every man
and woman has mourned alongside me."

□ OPEN-ENDED, LEONARD COHEN

"Ring the bells that still can ring
Forget your perfect offering
There is a crack in everything
That's how the light gets in"

Cohen, "Anthem." The crack as a simile for human imperfection, but he doesn't say that. He gives you the image and trusts you to make the connection. The "bells that still

The reed flute is the soul. Rumi doesn't explain why, he drops the ground and lets you feel your way to it. The silence around the comparison is the poem.

can ring" implies damaged ones, himself, all of us. Ground unstated, resonance total.

□ OPEN-ENDED, SA'DI

"گل همین پنج روز و شش باشد
وین گلستان همیشه خوش باشد
مرو ای دوست کز جهان رفتی
که جهان را بقاست و تو نه‌ای"

"The flower lasts only five or six days / But this rose garden is always beautiful / Don't go, friend, since you have left the world, / The world endures and you do not." The flower as life, but Sa'di places the two images side by side and lets you draw the line. Everything fragile, everything that endures. The comparison is in the gap between the lines.

□ OPEN-ENDED, EMILY DICKINSON

"*Hope' is the thing with feathers—
That perches in the soul—
And sings the tune without the words
—
And never stops—at all—*"

Dickinson, c. 1861. Hope compared to a bird, but the ground is never stated. Why a feathered thing? Why perching? The comparison arrives before any explanation, and the explanation never comes. What hope does — enduring without being asked, singing without an audience — is the whole point, and Dickinson trusts the image to carry it. Same instinct as Sa'di: drop the ground, let the reader feel their way to it.

□□ OPEN-ENDED, HAFEZ (THE CANDLE)

"چون شمع می‌گیرم در این محفل که دیده‌ام
از آتش اشکم چو شمع پیش از تو آب شوم
شمع می‌گیرد و می‌سوزد و می‌ریزد اشک
گوی این گریه و این سوز از بهر کیست"

"I weep in this gathering like a candle / From the fire of my tears I will melt before you like a candle / The candle weeps and burns and sheds tears / As if to ask: for whose sake is this weeping, this burning?" Hafez. The ground of the candle simile is never stated. You feel it before you name it: a candle burns itself to give others light, it melts in public, it weeps wax, it's consumed by the very fire that makes it visible. None of that is said. The image

□ OPEN-ENDED, TAYLOR SWIFT

*"So casually cruel in the name of
bein' honest
I'm a crumpled-up piece of paper
lyin' here
'Cause I remember it all, all, all"*

"All Too Well (10 Minute Version)" (2012). Subject: Taylor, post-relationship, post-confrontation. Standard: a crumpled piece of paper. Comparison particle: "I'm." Ground: completely unstated. She doesn't explain why she's like crumpled paper. She doesn't need to. The ground activates on contact: something that was written on and then discarded. Something that held words once and now holds only the shape of

lands and the reader supplies everything. This is tashbih-e mujmal at its most economical — a three-hundred-year tradition of Persian poets reaching for the same object because its unstated grounds are so obvious they don't need stating.

having been crushed. Something that could be smoothed out but never look the same again. All of that in four words. Sa'di's flower lasts five days before it's gone. The paper was thrown away and it's still lying there. Two images of damage across six centuries — neither one explains itself.

Tashbih-e Ma'kus, The Reversal

The poet makes a comparison and then flips it. "I compared your face to the moon, but then I realized: the moon is only beautiful because it reminds me of your face." The compliment escalates by demoting the very standard used to make it.

□ REVERSAL, SHAKESPEARE, SONNET 18

*"Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
Thou art more lovely and more temperate.
Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May,
And summer's lease hath all too short a date."*

Shakespeare opens by offering the comparison, then immediately downgrades it. The summer's day has flaws, rough winds, a short lease. The beloved has none of these. This is tashbih-e ma'kus in English: the comparison is proposed, then the standard is found lacking in the same breath.

□□ REVERSAL, HAFEZ

"هر که دید آن رخ و زلف از پی آن تافته
گفت کو آفتاب و کو شب تافته
آفتاب و ماه را خجل کند
رخ چون گل و زلف چون شب تافته"

"Whoever saw that face and those curls went searching, where is the sun now? Where is the moonlit night? / That rose-like face and night-like curls / Make both the sun and moon ashamed." After seeing the beloved, the sun and moon become the things being measured. The comparison reverses direction entirely.

Tashbih-e Sharti, The Conditional

The comparison only works in a hypothetical world. By saying what would need to change about the standard to match the subject, the poet implies: nothing in reality quite measures up.

بسرو ماند اگر بود دار لاله سرو
بمورد ماند اگر مورد روید از نسرين

"It would resemble a cypress if the cypress bore tulip flowers / It would resemble a myrtle if the myrtle grew from jasmine", Rudaki, father of Persian poetry (9th century). The conditional shrinks every standard. The beloved exceeds every category. This is the oldest trick in the book, making a compliment by pointing out what doesn't exist.

Tashbih-e Muzawwaj, The Chain

Multiple comparisons linked into one structure, not just A like B, but "A is to B as C is to D." The comparisons build off each other, creating a web rather than a single point.

□ CHAIN, ALLAMA IQBAL (URDU)

"ستاروں سے آگے جاں اور بھی ہیں
ابھی عشق کے امتحاں اور بھی ہیں
نئی زندگی سے نئی ہیں فضاں
یاں سینکڑوں کارواں اور بھی ہیں"

"Beyond the stars there are other worlds / There are still more trials of love ahead / These skies are not empty of life / Here too are hundreds more caravans." Iqbal links space to love to endurance, each comparison amplifies the others. The universe is a simile for longing, and longing is a simile for infinite possibility. They loop, building a chain.

□ CHAIN, BOB DYLAN

"How many roads must a man walk down
before you call him a man?
Yes, and how many seas must a white dove sail
before she sleeps in the sand?"

"Blowin' in the Wind." The chain of parallel "how many" questions builds a compound simile for injustice, each question is a different version of the same impossible waiting. The structure is the argument. Dylan's chain and Iqbal's chain are structurally the same move.

More Similes, Across the Whole Map

□ EPIC SIMILE, FERDOWSI, SHAHNAMEH

"چو شیر ژبان در میان سپاه
همی رفت پیروز با فَرّ و جاه
چو باد بهار از بر کوهسار
بیامد بر آن رزمگه بر نثار"

"Like a roaring lion in the midst of the army / He advanced, victorious, with glory and power / Like the spring wind from the mountaintop / He came scattering over that battlefield." Ferdowsi stacks two similes, lion for power, spring wind for speed, because one wasn't enough. Homer does the exact same thing for Achilles in the Iliad. Independent discovery, ten centuries apart.

□ KINSHIP SIMILE, HOMER

*"As is the generation of leaves, so too of men:
the wind scatters the leaves upon the ground,
but the growing forest burgeons with others
as the season of spring comes on."*

Homer, Iliad, Book VI (c. 8th century BCE). Glaucus delivers this to a warrior about to kill him — men like leaves, the shared quality (brevity, beauty, replacement by others) is never stated. The comparison does more than any argument could: life is brief, and part of a cycle bigger than either of us. A kinship simile where the two things are linked not by a word but by a situation. Homer didn't know Ferdowsi would reach for the same structure a thousand years later. He just knew the move.

□ GHALIB, FIRE SIMILE (URDU)

"عشق پر زور نہیں ہے و آتش غالب
کے لگاؤ کے لگے اور بجھاؤ کے بجھے
آگ ہے سب سے پہلے دل کے اندر
پھر جلتا ہے جاں بھی آشیانہ ہے"

"Love cannot be forced, it is a fire, Ghalib / That won't catch when you try, and won't die when you want / First the fire is inside the heart / Then it burns wherever there is a nest." The fire's behavior is the comparison, not just its heat or light, but its refusal to obey. A structural simile: the situation of fire parallels the situation of love.

□ STRUCTURAL SIMILE, EMILY DICKINSON

*"Because I could not stop for Death—
He kindly stopped for me—
The Carriage held but just Ourselves
—
And Immortality."*

Dickinson, c. 1862. Death compared to a gentleman caller who takes her for a carriage ride. Not just an image, a situation: his behavior (courteous, unhurried, patient) is the comparison. The carriage slows past the school, the fields, the setting sun. Death doesn't stalk. He waits. The fire's behavior was Ghalib's whole comparison. The suitor's behavior is

Dickinson's. A structural simile needs the situation to match, not just the object, and Dickinson's situation matches one of the oldest truths in Persian poetry: that the thing you fear most is also, somehow, the most courteous guest.

Tashbih-e Tamsil, The Analogy-Simile

The strongest similes don't compare object to object, they compare situation to situation. The ground isn't a single shared quality (bright, soft, fast) but a whole logical relationship. Persian calls this *tashbih-e tamsil*, the analogy-simile. Lupe Fiasco lives in this mode: his comparisons are little machines, not pictures.

□ TASHBIH, RUDAKI (C. 940 CE)

"بوی جوی مولیان آید همی
یاد یار مهربان آید همی
ریگ آموی و درشتی راه او
زیر پایم پرنیان آید همی"

"The scent of the Moliyan stream keeps coming / The memory of a kind friend keeps coming / The sand of the Amu and the roughness of its road / Feels like silk beneath my feet." The simile is in the last line: rough sand compared to *parniyan* (fine silk). But the ground isn't a shared physical quality, sand isn't soft. It's longing for home that transforms hardship into softness. The situation carries the comparison, not the object. Exactly Lupe's move, a thousand years earlier.

□ TASHBIH-E TAMSIL, LUPE FIASCO

کلمه به کلمه *Word-by-word*

But roosters don't fly like boosters don't buy

اما خروسها نمی پرند مثل دله دزدها نمی خرند

I run the Gambit like I'm throwing cards

من می چرخانم - گمبیت مثل دارم پرتاب ورقها

Paint cold pictures like Nova Scotia landscapes

می کشم سرد تصاویر مثل نوا اسکوشیا چشم اندازها

"Mural" (2015). None of these are picture-similes; they're analogy-similes. Roosters don't fly like boosters don't buy: just as a rooster can't fly, a "booster" (shoplifter) never pays, situation mapped onto situation, with the internal rhyme *roosters/boosters* locking it shut. Run the Gambit hides a second simile in a pun: he's both the card-throwing X-Man Gambit and "running the gamut" (the full range). And cold pictures like Nova Scotia landscapes compares his austere imagery to a frozen Canadian coast, the same transformation-

of-the-ground that turns Rudaki's rough sand to silk.

The Same Instinct, Across Every Tradition

Persian tashbih didn't appear in isolation. Across the Silk Road, in the Tang courts of China, in the haiku tradition of Japan, in ancient Greece and classical India, poets were working out the same problems under different names. The categories are different. The device is identical.

□ OPEN SIMILE, LI BAI (701-762 CE)

*"Before my bed, bright moonlight—
I take it for frost upon the ground.
Raising my head, I gaze at the bright moon;
Bowing my head, I think of home."*

"Quiet Night Thought" (静夜思), Li Bai, Tang Dynasty. The simile is in the first two lines: moonlight compared to frost. The shared quality (cold, pale, spreading silence) is unstated. Then the poem pivots away from the comparison into longing. The simile was just the door. Li Bai opens it and walks through into something else. Tashbih-e mujmal at its most economical: twenty Chinese characters, one image, a thousand years of readers thinking of home.

□ COMPRESSED SIMILE, MATSUO BASHO (1644-1694)

*"An old silent pond—
A frog jumps into the pond.
Splash! Silence again."*

Basho, 1686. The haiku contains no explicit comparison, but the structure IS one: the ancient pond (permanence, stillness) placed beside the frog's moment (disruption, sound), with silence immediately returning. Two things set next to each other without the comparison word, the reader feels the tension in the gap. This is tashbih compressed so far the "like" has evaporated entirely. Persian poets called this type the strongest kind. Basho arrived at the same conclusion from the opposite direction.

□ REVERSAL SIMILE, SAPPHO (C. 620-570 BCE)

*"Some say an army of horsemen,
some say infantry, some say a fleet
is the finest thing on the dark earth
—
I say it is whatever one loves."*

□ CHAIN SIMILE, KALIDASA (4TH-5TH CENTURY CE)

*"As the dark cloud brings relief to
the parched earth,
as the rain revives what the sun has
dried—
so the word from a beloved place*

Sappho, Fragment 16. The chain of "some say" examples (armies, infantry, fleet) are proposed standards, each one then demoted. Whatever one loves is the final term that defeats all of them. This is tashbih-e ma'kus, the reversal: the supposed standards are raised and then found lacking, because the actual subject exceeds every category. Hafez made the sun and moon ashamed. Sappho made armies irrelevant. Two poets, two islands, twenty-five hundred years apart, working the same reversal.

reaches one in exile like rain after drought."

Kalidasa, Meghaduta (Cloud Messenger), Sanskrit. The chain simile links cloud to rain to the beloved's message: each term amplifies the same feeling (relief after deprivation) until the emotion accumulates beyond what any single image could hold. Iqbal and Kalidasa were both mapping longing onto the cosmos, centuries apart and several languages east of each other. The Meghaduta's entire premise is a simile: use the monsoon cloud as a messenger because longing and rain both travel across impossible distances toward what they love.

Based on Hanjaar-e Goftar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939) & Bahar-e Adab journal (2013).

Drop the "Like." Make a Claim.

استعاره (Isti'ara)

A simile says "almost." A metaphor says "yes." That one-word difference is the distance between a description and a declaration, and it changes everything about how a line lands.

Start with a simile: "Her hair is like a river of darkness." Fine. Now remove the "like", "Her hair is a river of darkness." That's the first step toward Isti'ara (استعاره), what Persian rhetoric calls metaphor. Now go further: don't mention hair at all. "This dark river flows past her shoulders." You've stopped naming the subject. The metaphor has completely taken over.

That full takeover is what Isti'ara does at its most powerful. The vehicle (the comparison) replaces the subject so completely that the literal thing disappears. When Rumi writes about a reed flute crying, he's not mentioning the soul. When Hafez writes about wine, he's often not talking about wine. The comparison has absorbed the subject.

Isti'ara-ye Tasrihiyya, The Open Metaphor

The comparison is stated outright; the subject is hidden. "The lion entered the room", meaning a brave person. "Lion" is present; the brave person is implied. The most common English metaphor works exactly this way.

Isti'ara-ye Makniyya, The Implied Metaphor

The subject is named but the vehicle is hidden, only hinted at through one of its properties. "Death stretched out its hands", death is the subject, but the hidden vehicle (a predator, a reaper) appears only through the gesture. More haunting, more atmospheric.

The Reed Flute, The Most Famous Isti'ara in Persian

بشنو این نی چون شکایت می‌کند
از جدایی‌ها حکایت می‌کند
کز نیستان تا مرا ببریده‌اند
از نفیرم مرد و زن نالیده‌اند
سینه خواهم شرحه شرحه از فراق
تا بگویم شرح درد اشتیاق

"Listen to the reed flute, how it tells a tale of separations / Since they cut me from the reed bed / Every man and woman has mourned alongside me / I want a chest torn open by separation / So I can explain the pain of longing.", Rumi, opening of the Masnavi. The reed flute is the human soul. The reed bed is God, the origin, the place of union. Being cut from it is the fall into embodied existence. By the time Rumi has finished his first eighteen couplets, you've forgotten it's even a comparison.

آتش عشق است کاندر نی فتاد
جوشش عشق است کاندر می فتاد
نی حریف هر که از یاری برید
"پرده‌هایش پرده‌های ما درید"

Rumi, Masnavi, "It is the fire of Love that fell into the reed / It is the ferment of Love that fell into the wine. / The reed is the companion of anyone cut from a friend / Its melodies tore open our veils." Two isti'aras in one couplet: the reed as soul, the wine as love. The hidden vehicles (fire, ferment) suggest something alchemical and impossible to contain. Notice how Rumi uses both the reed and wine, two of the most charged symbols in all of Persian poetry, in the same breath.

John Donne and the Extended Isti'ara

The English poets closest to the Persian metaphor tradition are the Metaphysicals, Donne, Herbert, Marvell. They shared the Persian taste for the conceit: a metaphor stretched so far, through such unexpected connections, that it risks breaking, but somehow doesn't.

□ EXTENDED ISTI'ARA, HAFEZ

"می‌خور که عقل و دین را خواهی نشان دادن
این هر دو را شراب است آیینی تمام
ای دل غم این کار مخور یک جرعه می بزن
کاین عقده با ورع نگشاید ولی با می"

"Drink wine, if you want to reveal reason and faith / For wine is the perfect mirror of both. / O heart, don't grieve this, take one sip of wine / This knot won't be untied by piety, but by wine." Hafez extends the wine isti'ara until it becomes a mirror for the entire spiritual life. The metaphor absorbs both rationality and religion. The vehicle (wine) has replaced the tenor (spiritual experience) so completely that they're indistinguishable.

□ EXTENDED METAPHOR, JOHN DONNE

*"No man is an island entire of itself;
every man is a piece of the continent,
a part of the main;
if a clod be washed away by the sea,
Europe is the less"*

Donne, "Meditation XVII" (1624). A full extended metaphor: humanity as geography. The continent, the main, the clod washed away by the sea, each element adds a new layer to the same central image. Structurally, this is identical to Rumi's reed: one vehicle (geography) absorbs a complex subject (human connection and mortality) completely.

Hip-Hop Metaphor: Compressed and Immediate

If classical Persian isti'ara tends toward the extended and the spiritual, hip-hop tends toward the compressed and the material. But the move is the same, the vehicle replaces the tenor, the comparison word is gone, and the listener does the work.

□ ISTI'ARA-YE MAKNIYYA, BEDIL (DARI)

"زمانه خوابگه ما و مرگ بیداری است
بگو چه وقت کند خواب این نفس که بیداری
است"

□ COMPRESSED ISTI'ARA, LI BAI (701-762 CE)

*"Life in the world is but a great
dream;
why wear ourselves out with toil?"*

از خود شو تا بدانی آنچه گفتم
که عالم خواب ماست و ما بیداریم

"The world is our sleeping place, and death is the awakening / Tell me, when will this conscious breath finally sleep? / Lose yourself before you understand what I've said / The world is our dream and we are awake in it.", Bedil (1644-1720). Life as sleep, death as waking. The vehicle (a dream) is hidden, implied only through the behavior described. The reversal of the usual fear-of-death through a single implied metaphor.

*And so I spent my days in drinking,
lying helpless by the porch in front of
my door."*

"Spring Day: Waking from a Dream," Li Bai, Tang Dynasty. Life as dream, one complete isti'ara, and then the poem proves the metaphor by acting it out: he doesn't work, doesn't worry, lies at the door and drinks. The vehicle (dream) has replaced the tenor (life) so completely that his actual behavior becomes the evidence. Bedil's cosmological reversal and Li Bai's domestic one reach for the same image from different directions: the waking state may be the real sleep, and the world is not what it insists it is.

□□ GOOGOOSH, IRANIAN POP (1970S-NOW)

"تو رفتی و من موندم با این خونه‌ی سرد
که دیوارش آروم می‌گیره درد
دلم پیشته اما تنم اینجاست
دو نیمه شدم وقتی رفتی از کنارم"

"You left and I stayed with this cold house / Whose walls quietly absorb the pain / My heart is with you but my body is here / I was split in two when you left my side.", Googoosh, Iran's most iconic singer. The cold house as a metaphor for an empty life, an isti'ara-ye makniyya where the vehicle (the house) carries the weight of loss. A decade of grief compressed into an image of a room.

□ IMPLIED METAPHOR, EMILY DICKINSON

*"After great pain, a formal feeling
comes—
The Nerves sit ceremonious, like
Tombs—
The stiff Heart questions, was it He,
that bore,
And Yesterday, or Centuries before?"*

Dickinson, c. 1862. The whole poem is an implied metaphor: grief as a kind of numbness that performs normality. The Nerves become ceremonious (like mourners at a funeral). The Heart becomes a questioner that has lost track of time. No one says "I am grieving." The poem's own stiffness, its formal grammar, is the metaphor, the vehicle is the poem itself. Googoosh's cold house and Dickinson's formal ceremony are the same isti'ara-ye makniyya, the empty room and the stiff procedure both saying the thing that can't be said directly.

Isti'ara-ye Tamsiliyya, The Allegory

Stretch an isti'ara far enough and it stops being a single metaphor and becomes a whole dramatized scene that means something else, start to finish. Persian calls this isti'ara-ye tamsiliyya, the allegorical metaphor. A tavern, a painter's studio, a reed bed: the surface is one thing, every prop in it points to another.

□ ALLEGORY, HAFEZ (THE TAVERN SCENE)

"حافظ به زیر خرقه قدح می‌کشیده است
ای شیخ پاکدامن معذور دارش خوش
می‌خور که عقل و دین را خواهی نشان دادن
این هر دو را شراب است آیینی تمام"

"Hafez was drinking a cup beneath his cloak / O pure-hearted sheikh, forgive him kindly. / Drink wine, if you'd reveal both reason and faith / For wine is the perfect mirror of both." The cup hidden under the cloak, the scolding sheikh, the wine that mirrors the soul, none of it is literally about a drink. The whole little scene is an allegory: concealment, forbidden truth, the divine hidden inside the worldly. Every object in the room means something it isn't.

□ ISTI'ARA-YE TAMSILIIYYA, LUPE FIASCO

کلمه به کلمه *Word-by-word*

Life is not a dictionary, it's a thesaurus
زندگی - نیست یک لغت‌نامه بلکه یک مترادف‌نامه
I sit back and watch the world through
eye holes in my oil paintings

من می‌نشینم عقب و تماشا - جهان از خلال چشم
سوراخ‌های در - روغنی نقاشی‌های

"Mural" & "Ms. Mural" (2015). The whole of Ms. Mural is one sustained allegory: a painter and a wealthy patron talk about a canvas, but the scene is really about the artist facing the critic and the market, and it ends with the painter dousing the patron-as-model in gasoline and setting the work on fire. The single line Life is not a dictionary, it's a thesaurus is a compact implied metaphor, life isn't fixed single definitions but a web of synonyms and alternatives. And watch the world through eye holes in my oil paintings is isti'ara-ye makniyya, the maker concealed inside his own work, present only as a gaze. Hafez hid under a cloak; Lupe hides inside a painting.

□ EXTENDED ISTI'ARA, KABIR (15TH CENTURY)

□ EXTENDED ISTI'ARA, TAYLOR SWIFT

*"Jhini jhini bini chadariya
Chaadar bini ke kaahe ne jaanta
Aath kamal dal charkha doole
Pach tatva gun teeni"*

"Finely, finely woven is this cloth / Who wove it, and why does no one know? / Eight lotus petals, the spinning wheel turns / Five elements, three qualities." Kabir was a weaver by trade, and the loom runs across his entire body of work: the body is cloth on God's loom, the soul is the thread, death is the cloth being cut free. No single poem announces this. The vehicle accumulates across dozens of dohas and bhajans, each time arriving at the weaving image from a different angle. By the time you've read enough Kabir, "cloth" or "thread" or "loom" carries the whole philosophy: everything woven from the same material, everything temporary, everything returned to the maker. The isti'ara is not contained in any one poem. It builds across a life's work the way a weaving builds across a loom.

*"And I left my scarf there at your
sister's house
And you've still got it in your drawer,
even now*

...
*You keep my old scarf from that very
first week
'Cause it reminds you of innocence
and it smells like me
You can't get rid of it"*

"All Too Well (10 Minute Version)" (2012). The scarf appears in line four of the first verse and returns in the final verse, after ten minutes of song covering an entire relationship. In between: the whole arc. The scarf in verse one is just a scarf. By verse five, after the kitchen dancing and the car keys and the argument and the aging, it's the relationship itself — what he couldn't commit to in life and can't discard in memory. Something that smells like someone. Something that sits in a drawer and proves a person existed in your life before things went wrong. The object never becomes an explicit metaphor. Taylor Swift never says "the scarf is our relationship." She doesn't have to. The isti'ara builds through accumulation and return, the same way Kabir's loom does: quietly, across a long time, until one small humble object holds everything that can't be said directly.

Why "Is" Hits Harder Than "Like"

Persian criticism made this argument precisely: isti'ara is stronger than tashbih because it makes a stronger claim. A simile says "these two things are similar." A metaphor says "these two things are each other." One is a

comparison, the other is an assertion. The listener has to reckon with an assertion in a way they don't have to with a comparison.

The English philosopher Max Black made almost exactly this argument in 1955: metaphors don't just compare but actively create new meanings by "filtering" one concept through another. He didn't cite Persian rhetoric. He didn't need to. He was describing the same phenomenon, and arriving at the same conclusion a thousand years later.

The one-line version: Tashbih says "almost." Isti'ara says "yes." The gap between them is exactly where poetry happens.

Based on Hanjaar-e Goftar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939) & Bahar-e Adab journal (2013).

Hafez Was Probably Not Talking About Wine

مجاز و کنایه (Majaz va Kinaya)

Majaz and Kinaya, the art of saying one thing while meaning another. Plausible deniability, double meaning, and why the most honest writing is sometimes the most indirect.

Sometimes the most powerful sentence is the one that doesn't commit. Not because the writer is vague, but because the indirection itself is doing something the direct statement couldn't. It implicates the reader. It creates a felt knowledge rather than a stated one. It gives both writer and reader cover.

Persian rhetoric has two tools for this. Majaz (مجاز) is using a word in a non-literal sense because of a real, recognizable connection between its literal meaning and what you intend, what English calls metonymy or synecdoche. Kinaya (کنایه) is saying something literally true while meaning something else entirely, implication rather than substitution. Both are everywhere in classical Persian poetry. Both show up in hip-hop and pop music constantly.

Majaz, When One Word Stands in for Its Neighbor

"The White House announced today", the building didn't speak. The government did. The building stands in for the institution because there's a real, recognizable relationship between them. That's majaz. The substitution works because the connection is genuine, not arbitrary, not random.

MAJAZ AS ETHICS, SA'DI

"بنی آدم اعضای یک پیکرند
که در آفرینش ز یک گوهرند

MAJAZ IN HIP-HOP

"The pen is mightier than the sword.
I got the streets on lock.

چو عضوی به درد آورد روزگار
دگر عضوها را نماند قرار

"The children of Adam are parts of one body / Created from one essence / When one member suffers with pain / The other members cannot rest.", Sa'di, Golestan. "Members of one body" is synecdoche (part for whole) turned into an ethical argument. The physical relationship carries a moral imperative. This is now on the wall of the United Nations, which is either very fitting or deeply ironic, depending on the day you're reading the news.

*The crown weighs heavy.
We bleeding the same color."*

Pen for the writer's full creative and moral power. Streets for their people and their respect. Crown for the burden of leadership. Bleeding the same for shared humanity. All majaz, one concrete word standing in for a larger reality through a connection that's real, not made up. This language runs through hip-hop because it runs through human expression everywhere and always has.

Kinaya, Saying It Without Saying It

Kinaya is trickier and more interesting than majaz. It's not substitution, it's saying something literally true while meaning something completely different. "He has long hands", literally possible. But in Persian and Arabic idiom, it implies either generosity (his hands reach far to give) or dishonesty (his hands reach into things they shouldn't). Both literal readings work. The implication is what the writer intends.

This gives kinaya something no other device has: plausible deniability baked into the poem itself.

This is exactly why Hafez's enemies couldn't censor him. His poems were technically about wine, taverns, and pretty faces, all forbidden, none of it explicitly political or heretical. But everyone understood what they were really about: spiritual longing, resistance to religious hypocrisy, the gap between outward piety and inner truth. The literal reading was always available as cover. Poetry as legal defense. There's something beautiful and a little reckless about that.

The Hafez Wine Problem

Hafez's Divan, consulted like an oracle for 600 years, sitting next to the Quran in households across the Persian-speaking world, is soaked in wine, taverns, and cupbearers. All technically forbidden in Islam. Scholars have argued for centuries: is this literal? Mystical? Both?

The honest answer: yes to both, simultaneously, on purpose. That simultaneous double reading is kinaya at its most sophisticated.

الا يا ايها الساقى ادر كأسا و ناولها
که عشق آسان نمود اول ولی افتاد مشکلها
ما در پیاله عکس رخ یار دیده‌ایم
ای بی‌خبر ز لذت شرب مدام ما

"Come, O Cupbearer, pass the cup and offer it / For love seemed easy at first, but then difficulties fell upon us. / We have seen the reflection of the Beloved's face in the cup, / O you who are unaware of the joy of our constant drinking." The cupbearer (saqi) is literally a wine-server; implied: a divine intermediary, a Sufi guide. The wine (mai) is literally fermented grape; implied: ecstasy, divine knowledge, the dissolving of the ego. He doesn't ask you to choose a reading. The poem lives in both at once.

□□ KINAYA, HAFEZ

"می‌خور که عقل و دین را خواهی نشان دادن
این هر دو را شراب است آیینه‌ی تمام
ای دل غم این کار مخور یک جرعه می بزن
کاین عقده با ورع نگشاید ولی با می"

"Drink wine, if you want to reveal reason and faith / For wine is the perfect mirror of both. / O heart, don't grieve this, take one sip of wine / This knot won't be untied by piety, but by wine." The "knot" is both personal anguish and the theological gap between law and love. The wine is both literal and spiritual. And Hafez names himself committing the forbidden act while

□ KINAYA, BOB DYLAN

*"The answer, my friend, is blowin' in the wind
The answer is blowin' in the wind
How many years can some people exist
before they're allowed to be free?"*

"Blowin' in the Wind." The wind is kinaya: literally air movement, implied something at once everywhere and impossible to grab, justice, peace, the moral obligation of the powerful. The answer IS out there. It just won't stay still long enough to be caught. Dylan's wind and Hafez's wine are the

defending it philosophically. The pun is the argument.

same device: one thing standing in for another, with the literal reading intact for cover.

Ghalib's Wounds, Kinaya in Urdu

□ KINAYA, GHALIB (URDU)

"دل ڈھونڈتا ہے بھر واپسی فرصتِ شب و روز
بیٹھ رہا ہے تصوّرِ جانان کی آویز
نادان ہے جو کلمہ کہے کہ کیوں زندہ ہے میں غالب
قسمت میں ہے مرنا تو ابھی تک نہیں مرا"

"The heart again searches for that leisure of night and day / To sit absorbed in the image of the beloved. / You are foolish to ask why Ghalib is still alive, / If death is my fate, I simply haven't died yet." The final couplet is pure kinaya: literally, Ghalib explains his survival through logic. Actually, he's describing the unbearable persistence of longing, living is the wound, dying would be the relief. The logic covers the grief.

□ KINAYA, WILLIAM BLAKE

*"I wander thro' each charter'd street,
Near where the charter'd Thames
does flow,
And mark in every face I meet
Marks of weakness, marks of woe."*

Blake, "London" (1794). "Charter'd" means both surveyed (put on a map) and legally owned. The literal meaning (streets on a city plan) is true. The implied meaning (a city where everything, including the river, has been turned into property) is what Blake intends. The repetition of "marks" at the end works the same way: facial expressions on the surface, invisible wounds of a society underneath. Blake and Hafez are both writing things that mean two things simultaneously and refusing to resolve the ambiguity. The literal reading is always available as cover. The real reading is everything underneath it.

□ KINAYA, AHMAD ZAHIR

"دلہم گرفتہ از این شهر پر ملال و غبار
کجاست آن رفیقِ همدرد و آن دیار
دیگر نه آن وطن است و نه آن یار
نه آن چراغِ روشن و نه آن بهار"

"My heart is heavy in this sad, dusty city / Where is that understanding friend, that homeland / There is no longer that homeland, nor that friend / Neither that

□ KINAYA, THE BEATLES

*"Yesterday, all my troubles seemed
so far away
Now it looks as though they're here
to stay
Oh I believe in yesterday
Suddenly I'm not half the man I used
to be"*

bright light nor that spring." Ahmad Zahir singing in the 1970s, "this city" is literally Kabul. But "that homeland" is kinaya for something more than a place: a state of being, a time before loss, a self before war. The song means both the city and everything the city can no longer hold.

"Yesterday" is kinaya: literally the previous day, actually the whole prior self, the whole prior life. "Not half the man I used to be" is kinaya working twice, literally a statement about diminishment, actually a statement about grief and self-fracture. McCartney and Ahmad Zahir are writing the same song in different decades, different alphabets, the same feeling.

□ KINAYA BY NEGATION, HAFEZ

نه هر که چهره برافروخت دلبری داند
نه هر که آینه سازد سکندری داند
نه هر که طرف کله کج نهاد و تند نشست
کلاه‌داری و آیین سروری داند

"Not everyone who brightens their face knows how to charm / Not everyone who makes a mirror knows the way of Alexander / Not everyone who tilts their hat and sits sharply / Knows the art of leadership or the customs of lordship." Hafez. The device is *na har ke* (not everyone who): each line names the surface sign — the bright face, the polished mirror, the tilted hat — and then refuses to let it stand as the real thing. The true thing (genuine charm, real power, actual authority) is never named. It exists entirely in the space the negation opens between the denied surface and the reader's inference. This is kinaya by negation: the implied meaning is produced not by stating the thing but by dismantling every false version of it, one by one, until only the truth remains in the gap.

□ KINAYA BY NEGATION, SKIP MARLEY

*"I know you drunk in power, brother,
that's not juice
I see you chasing Mil's, my brother,
that's not food
When the banana peels, I tell you
that's not fruit
Another brother shot down, but
that's not news"*

"That's Not True" (615), Skip Marley (2024). Four consecutive negations, each naming what something is not in order to define what it actually is. "Drunk in power, that's not juice" — the intoxication is real, the substance corrupt. "Banana peels, that's not fruit" — the fall is coming and the sweetness is already gone. "Shot down, that's not news" — the real scandal is that this has stopped being scandalous. In every case the literal denial ("that's not juice") is kinaya for a moral reality Skip never states outright. He never says "power corrupts" or "our community is desensitized to death." He says what these things are not, and the what-they-actually-are lands harder for never being named. Hafez built the same structure around false leadership. Skip builds it around survival. Both use negation not as refusal but as the clearest path to the truth.

Kinaya at the Scale of a Song

The most sophisticated kinaya isn't a line or a couplet — it's a whole narrative that carries two complete readings simultaneously for its entire length. The literal story works. The implied story works. And when the implied story finally surfaces, it recontextualizes everything that came before it.

□ EXTENDED KINAYA, HAFEZ (WINE = DIVINE LOVE)

"الا يا ايها الساقى ادر كاسا و ناولها
كه عشق آسان نمود اول ولى افتاد مشكلها
ما در پياله عكس رخ يار ديده ايم
اي بى خبر ز لذت شرب مدام ما"

"Come, O Cupbearer, pass the cup / For love seemed easy at first, but difficulties fell. / We have seen the reflection of the Beloved's face in the cup, / O you unaware of the joy of our constant drinking." The whole Divan runs on this double reading: wine is wine and wine is ecstasy. The cupbearer is a server and a spiritual guide. Hafez never resolves which is which. The ambiguity is the device. His enemies couldn't censor him because the literal reading was always available as cover.

□ EXTENDED KINAYA, KENDRICK LAMAR

*"How much a dollar cost?
The question is detrimental,
paralyzin' my thoughts
...
You're lookin' at the Messiah, the son
of Jehovah, the higher power
The choir that spoke the word, the
Holy Spirit
The nerve of Nazareth, and I'll tell
you just how much a dollar cost
The price of having a spot in Heaven,
embrace your loss—I am God"*

"How Much a Dollar Cost" (2015). For three full verses, the song is literally about a homeless man asking Kendrick for a dollar outside a gas station, and Kendrick refusing. The literal reading is complete: an uncomfortable encounter, guilt, rationalizations. The implied reading surfaces only at the end when the homeless man says "I am God." Every prior detail recontextualizes: every refusal was a theological failure, every rationalization a spiritual one. The dollar was never about money. Hafez's wine held two meanings simultaneously across a whole Divan. Kendrick holds two meanings across a single song and detonates the hidden one at the final line.

Based on Hanjaar-e Gofar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939) & Bahar-e Adab journal (2013).

The Tricks That Stick at 3am

بدیع ('Badi)

Puns, antithesis, parallelism, beautiful causation. The last 20% of the craft that accounts for 80% of what people actually remember. Badi' is where a good line becomes an unforgettable one.

You've built a sentence with clean structure. You've loaded it with a vivid image. And it's still fine. Competent. Forgettable. Something's missing.

What's missing is Badi', the layer that makes a line stay in the brain. Wordplay. Pairing opposites so they charge each other. Sound work that you feel before you understand. Giving a poetic, magical reason for something instead of the real one. These aren't decoration on top of the poem. At their best, they're the reason the poem exists.

Tajnis, The Pun (But Make It Mean Something)

In English, puns are groan-worthy. In Persian and Arabic poetry, a well-placed tajnis (تجنیس), two words that sound the same but mean completely different things, is a mark of real craft. Not a cheap laugh, but a cognitive double-exposure: two meanings activating at the same time, each illuminating the other.

□ TAJNIS, RUMI (THE HIDDEN ONE)

"بشنو این نی چون شکایت می‌کند
از جدایی‌ها حکایت می‌کند
کز نیستان تا مرا ببریده‌اند
از نفیرم مرد و زن نالیده‌اند"

"Listen to this nay (reed) / how it complains...", In Persian, nay means both the reed flute and "no" / "never." The reed

□ TAJNIS CHAIN, LUPE FIASCO

کلمه به کلمه Word-by-word

I prefer girls to reign all over the world
من ترجیح می‌دهم دختران که سلطنت کنند سراسرِ --
جهان

And not 'rain' like 'Rain Man' or rain like
'rain dance'

و نه باران مثلی مردبارانی یا باران مثلی رقص باران

crying out is also the reed saying "no, no, no", refusing separation, refusing incompleteness. The tajnis is built into the very first word of the Masnavi. Rumi's entire poem begins with a pun so deep most readers don't even catch it.

Or rain like a 'slight chance of rain' when it's rainin'

یا باران مثل یک اندک احتمال - باران وقتی - می بارد

Or 'rein' like deer slaves to Santa Claus sleigh man

یا افسار مثل گوزن‌های برده برای بابانوئل - سورتمه -

But 'reign' like queens that reign over made man

اما سلطنت مثل ملکه‌ها که حکومت می‌کنند بر مافیایی
مرد

"Mural" (2015). One sound — reign/rain/rein — run through seven different meanings in five lines: royal dominance, a film title, a cultural ritual, weather, weather forecast, equestrian control, and back to sovereignty. This is tajnis-e muraqqab (compound chain pun) in its most elaborate form. Persian Badi' scholars classified this type separately from the single pun because the effect is different: it isn't a double exposure, it's a prism. Rumi's nay/no in the first word of the Masnavi is the seed; this is what it looks like at full bloom.

□ TAJNIS, HAFEZ (WINE/MIRROR)

"حافظ به زیر خرقه قدح می‌کشیده است
ای شیخ پاکدامن معذور دارش خوش
می‌خور که عقل و دین را خواهی نشان دادن
این هر دو را شراب است آیینی تمام"

"Hafez was drinking a cup under his cloak / O pure-hearted sheikh, please forgive him kindly. / Drink wine, if you want to reveal reason and faith / For wine is the perfect mirror of both.", Hafez names himself committing the forbidden act in the final couplet (the maqta), then defends it philosophically in the same breath. The tajnis runs through the whole ghazal: literal wine and spiritual wine are the same

□ SOUND CASCADE, EDGAR ALLAN POE

*"Once upon a midnight dreary, while
I pondered, weak and weary,
Over many a quaint and curious
volume of forgotten lore—
While I nodded, nearly napping,
suddenly there came a tapping,
As of some one gently rapping,
rapping at my chamber door."*

Poe, "The Raven" (1845). Dreary/weary, nodded/napping, tapping/rapping: a deliberate cascade of near-homophones that builds dread before the content even lands. This is tajnis-e naqes (imperfect pun,

sound, and Hafez refuses to distinguish them.

one sound off) used as atmosphere, not wit. Poe wrote an entire essay, "The Philosophy of Composition," defending his sound choices rationally. Persian Badi' scholars would have read it and nodded. The mechanism he describes is exactly what they classified.

Tibaq, Pairing Opposites

Put two opposites in the same line and they charge each other. Day/night. Life/death. Presence/absence. Tibaq (طباق) is the Persian-Arabic name for antithesis, and it works in every language because opposition is one of the brain's most basic tools for making meaning. The two ends of a spectrum define each other and make visible the whole space between them.

□□ TIBAQ, IQBAL (URDU)

"تو شب آفریدی، چراغ آفریدم
سفال آفریدی، ایاج آفریدم
بیابان و کوهسار و راغ آفریدی
خیابان و گلشن و باغ آفریدم"

"You created the night, I created the lamp / You created clay, I created the cup / You created the wilderness, the mountain, the meadow / I created the boulevard, the rose garden, the orchard.", Iqbal in conversation with God. Each line is a tibiaq: darkness vs. light, raw material vs. shaped form, wild nature vs. cultivated garden. The antithesis is the argument, human creativity as a response to divine creation. Four lines of opposition that build into a theology.

□ TIBAQ, SHAKESPEARE, HAMLET

*"To be, or not to be, that is the question:
Whether 'tis nobler in the mind to suffer
The slings and arrows of outrageous fortune,
Or to take arms against a sea of troubles"*

Be/not-be. Suffer/take arms. The most famous antithesis in English literature is pure tibiaq. The paired opposites hold open a philosophical space, neither option wins, and the inability to choose IS the condition being described. Compare this to Iqbal's tibiaq: both use opposition to make an argument that a direct statement couldn't carry.

□□ TIBAQ, BEDIL (DARI)

□ TIBAQ, WILLIAM BLAKE

"زمانه خوابگه ما و مرگ بیداری است
 بگو چه وقت کند خواب این نفس که بیداری
 است
 از خود شو تا بدانی آنچه گفتم
 که عالم خواب ماست و ما بیداریم"

"The world is our sleeping place, and death is the awakening / Tell me, when will this conscious breath finally sleep? / Lose yourself before you understand what I've said / The world is our dream and we are awake in it.", Bedil's tibiaq runs across the whole poem: sleep/waking, world/death, losing yourself/understanding. The opposites don't cancel, they spiral around each other until the distinction collapses.

"Tyger Tyger, burning bright,
 In the forests of the night;
 What immortal hand or eye,
 Could frame thy fearful symmetry?"

Blake, "The Tyger" (1794). Every image runs on antithesis: bright burning against dark forests; immortal hand against fearful symmetry; the creator's tenderness against the creature's violence. Blake built the whole collection, Songs of Innocence and Experience, as one giant tibiaq. "The Tyger" and its companion piece "The Lamb" are two poles charged by each other, each defined by what the other is. The antithesis is the argument, the same as Iqbal's conversation with God, just with different theology underneath.

□ TIBAQ, OMAR KHAYYAM

"از آمدنم نبود گردون را سود
 وز رفتن من جلال و جاهش نفزود
 وز هیچ کسی نیز دو گوشم نشنود
 کاین آمدن و رفتنم از بهر چه بود"

"My coming brought the turning heavens no gain / Nor did my going add to its glory or rank / Nor have my two ears ever heard from anyone / Why this coming and going of mine was for." Khayyam. The whole quatrain runs on one tibiaq, amadan / raftan (coming / going), repeated until the pair becomes the entire question of existence. The opposites don't resolve; they hold the void open between them.

□ TIBAQ, LUPE FIASCO

کلمه به کلمه Word-by-word

So the sun rise when the beat drop
 پس - خورشید برمی آید وقتی - ضرب می افتد
 and the sun dies when the beat stops
 و - خورشید می میرد وقتی - ضرب می ایستد
 Born to death, born to die — immortalize
 زاده برای مرگ زاده برای مردن - جاودانه کن

"Mural" and "Mural Jr." (2015). Two clean antitheses. The sun rise when the beat drop, and the sun dies when the beat stops: rise / dies and drop / stops, charged against each other so the rhythm of the track becomes a tiny cosmology. And Born to death... immortalize sets mortality directly against permanence, the same move Khayyam makes with coming and going. The opposites define the whole space between them.

□ **RAPID TIBAQ, SA'DI (GOLESTAN, 13TH CENTURY)**

"زندگی با آبرو بهتر از مرگ با ذلت
دوستی با دانا بهتر از معاشرت با نادان
دانش بی عمل چون درخت بی ثمر
توانگری با خست بدتر از درویشی"

"Life with honor is better than death in disgrace / Friendship with the wise is better than companionship with fools / Knowledge without action is like a tree without fruit / Wealth with miserliness is worse than poverty." Sa'di, Golestan. Sa'di's preferred teaching mode is the rapid-fire preference comparison — what Persian rhetoric calls *mufadala* (تفضیل), the stacking of "better than" pairs until the opposites build a moral argument by accumulation. Each pair is its own closed proof: honor over disgrace, wisdom over foolishness, action over knowledge that stays inert. The reader moves through them quickly because each one is obvious — obvious in a way that makes you wonder why you had to be told. That's the trick. Tibaq made into proverb.

□ **MUFADALA CHAIN, DAMIAN MARLEY**

*"Better you build a bridge, than
instead of you build a wall
Better to love and lost, than to never
have loved at all
Real is better than fraud
Freedom better than bought
Gold is better than bronze, but
Health is better than wealth, and
Peace is better than war
Now is better than later
The present is better than past"*

"That's Not True" (615), Damian Marley (2024). Seventeen "better than" pairs in a single verse, each one answered by the crowd's "a lie?" — a call-and-response that challenges every proverb even as they accumulate. The verse doesn't make one argument. It stacks an entire moral cosmology through opposition pairs: real/fraud, freedom/bought, health/wealth, peace/war, now/after. Each pair is a *tibaq*. Together they create a semantic field of human values all ranged against their opposite, the same move Sa'di makes in the Golestan but compressed from chapters into thirty seconds of reggae. The "a lie?" refrain is what makes it live: it introduces doubt into each antithesis, asking whether even the obvious pairs hold. Sa'di's pairs are delivered as certainties. Marley's are delivered as certainties that the crowd is invited to question. The compression is the achievement. The doubt is the philosophy.

□ **SINGLE-LINE TIBAQ, GHALIB (URDU)**

"عاشقی صبر طلب اور تمنا ِ تاب
دل کا کیا رنگ کروں خونِ جگر ِ تونہ تک"

□ **SINGLE-LINE TIBAQ, TAYLOR SWIFT**

*"You kept me like a secret, but I kept
you like an oath"*

"Love demands patience, but desire is restless / What color shall I paint my heart until it bleeds?" The tibiaq is in the first half: sabr-talab (demanding patience) against be-tab (without endurance, restless). These are not merely opposites — they name the same thing, love, tearing itself in two directions simultaneously. Patience and restlessness are both love's properties, and they contradict each other completely. Ghalib uses one line to hold a contradiction that most poets would need a stanza to unpack. The opposition is not a rhetorical ornament. It is the diagnosis.

"All Too Well (10 Minute Version)" (2012). One line, two parallel structures, two opposite intentions built from the same syntax. Secret vs. oath: one is a thing you hide, the other is a thing you swear to. One is concealment, the other is sacred commitment. Both are things you keep. The parallelism — kept me like / kept you like — makes the opposition more brutal, not less, because the syntax is identical and only the meaning diverges. The line doesn't need a verse around it. It is a complete argument about asymmetrical love in eleven words. Ghalib diagnosed the contradiction from the inside of the feeling. Swift names it from the outside looking in, which turns out to be considerably colder.

□ STRUCTURAL TIBAQ, SURAH AL-LAYL (THE NIGHT, 92)

وَاللَّيْلِ إِذَا يَغْشَى
وَالنَّهَارِ إِذَا تَجَلَّى
وَمَا خَلَقَ الذَّكَرَ وَالْأُنثَى

"By the night when it covers / By the day when it appears / And by He who created male and female." Three tibiaq pairs in the opening three verses: night/day, covers/appears, male/female. In Arabic rhetorical tradition, the Quran is the supreme source of badi' — the devices aren't decorating the text, they are the structure of the argument. These pairs aren't ornament. They are the cosmological logic. Opposites as the grammar of creation itself.

□ TIBAQ + HIDDEN TAJNIS, LUPE FIASCO, "PRISONER"

*"Love is looking over various errors
And hate is habitually accelerating
terror
Everywhere, but the mirror"*

The tibiaq is surface-level: love/hate, the oldest antithesis in the language. But each word is also a hidden acrostic of its own definition: L.O.V.E. = Looking Over Various Errors. H.A.T.E. = Habitually Accelerating Terror. The two devices double back on each other — the tibiaq (two opposites charging each other) becomes a tajnis (each word doing double duty as itself and its own encrypted meaning). Classical Badi' documented tibiaq and tajnis as separate devices. Lupe fires both from the same four-letter word, twice, in one couplet. "Everywhere, but the mirror" extends the tibiaq outward: both love and hate exist out there; only the self refuses the reckoning.

That half-line is the whole argument of the song.

Husn-e Ta'lil, The Beautiful Lie

One of Badi's most charming devices: instead of giving the real reason why something is the way it is, you give a poetically satisfying imaginary reason. The stars are bright because angels polished them. The rose is red because it blushed. The nightingale sings because it's in love with the flower and can't stop. These "beautiful causes" aren't true in any physical sense, but they're emotionally true, and they re-enchant a world that factual explanation flattens.

□□ HUSN-E TA'LIL, HAFEZ

"رنگ رخساره نگر زردی روی بلبل
که از روی گل است این همه گلرنگ رخسارش
می‌نشیند پیش گل بلبل به صد ناز و ادب
گویا این هر دو در یک مکتب آموزیده‌اند"

"Look at the pallor of the nightingale's face, / Its rosy cheeks come from looking at the rose. / The nightingale sits before the rose with a hundred elegances, / It's as though both of them learned in the same school.", Hafez explains the nightingale's coloring not through biology but through love: it blushes from the rose's reflection. False in physics. True in everything else.

□ BEAUTIFUL CAUSATION, KEATS

*"A thing of beauty is a joy for ever:
Its loveliness increases; it will never
Pass into nothingness; but still will
keep
A bower quiet for us, and a sleep"*

Keats, "Endymion." The reason beautiful things endure isn't explained, the cause offered is circular: they endure because they're beautiful. That fantastical reasoning is husn-e ta'lil. And it works, not because it's true but because it's what we want to be true. That gap between the literal truth and the wished-for truth is where Badi' lives.

□□ HUSN-E TA'LIL, OMAR KHAYYAM

"آن قصر که جمشید در او جام گرفت
آهو بچه کرد و روبه آرام گرفت
بهرام که گور می‌گرفت می‌همه عمر
دید که چگون گور بهرام گرفت"

□ HUSN-E TA'LIL, KENDRICK LAMAR, "DUCKWORTH."

*"You take two strangers and put 'em
in random predicaments
Give 'em a soul, so they can make
their own choices and live with it"*

"That palace where Jamshid held his cup /
Now a fawn gives birth and a fox rests
peacefully. / Bahram who hunted the wild
ass his whole life — / See now how the
grave hunted Bahram." Khayyam. The
explanation for why the palace fell and
Bahram died is not historical or political —
it's karmic, poetic, almost playful. The
same word (gur) means both "wild ass" and
"grave" in Persian. Bahram hunted his
whole life, and the hunt reversed on him.
The beautiful cause is: nature's justice. The
real cause was history. Khayyam chose the
more satisfying one.

*Twenty years later, them same
strangers, you make 'em meet again
Inside recording studios where they
reapin' their benefits
Then you start remindin' them about
that chicken incident
Whoever thought the greatest rapper
would be from coincidence?"*

"DUCKWORTH." (2017). The real reason
Kendrick exists: his father Ducky worked at
a KFC, gave free chicken to gang leader
Top Dawg, and Top Dawg didn't rob the
place and kill him. A mundane transaction
saved a life that produced an artist.
Kendrick gives the beautiful cause: not
luck, not chance, but God arranging two
strangers across twenty years. "Whoever
thought the greatest rapper would be from
coincidence?" The poetic reason is: it
wasn't coincidence. That's husn-e ta'lil. The
truth of the device isn't in its accuracy but
in its emotional rightness. And on DAMN.,
the outro plays the whole album in reverse
— the story undone — which is what
happens if the beautiful cause fails.

Mura'at al-Nazir, Using Words That Belong Together

This is one of Badi's subtler moves: filling a poem with words from the same semantic family so they create coherence below the level of explicit meaning. When a poem about longing also contains night, candle, moth, desert, and wanderer, all those words belong to the same Persian "field of longing." Their co-presence is deliberate. It creates an atmosphere that goes beyond what any single image could produce.

The classic Persian semantic field is gol o bolbol, flower and nightingale. They appear together in hundreds of ghazals because they form a complete

emotional ecosystem: the nightingale loves the flower, suffers for it, sings because of it, exists in relation to it. Using both activates the whole mythology immediately. It's like a hip-hop artist name-dropping a specific block, anyone who knows the city knows exactly what that carries.

□ FIELD HARMONY, HAFEZ

"ز کوی یار می‌آید نسیم باد نوروزی
از این باد ار مدد خواهی چراغ دل فروزی
به صحرا رو که از دامن کوه و دشت و دریا
هزاران نکته دارد گنج زر در گوشه‌ای"

"From the street of the Beloved comes the New Year breeze / From this wind, seek help, and the candle of your heart lights. / Go to the open field, from the lap of mountain, plain, and sea / There are thousands of subtleties, a treasure of gold in every corner." Breeze, candle, mountain, sea, spring, all in the same emotional field: renewal, seeking, the promise of something found. The semantic coherence does work that no individual image could.

□ FIELD HARMONY, WALT WHITMAN

*"I celebrate myself, and sing myself,
And what I assume you shall assume,
For every atom belonging to me as
good belongs to you.
I loafe and invite my soul."*

Whitman, "Song of Myself" (1855). Celebrate/sing/assume/belonging/soul: every word in the opening belongs to the semantic field of shared being, the self as continuous with the world and with the reader. Whitman loads the poem with words from one family so they amplify each other before you've consciously noticed the pattern. The field is: selfhood, extension, union. The coherence is felt before it's understood. Mura'at al-Nazir at the scale of an epic. Hafez used flowers and nightingales; Whitman used atoms and loafing. Same move.

□ FIELD HARMONY, HOMER (C. 8TH CENTURY BCE)

*"As when the shimmering waves are
stirred by the West Wind,
heaping the dark water and the
white crests break on shore—
so the battalions of Achaeans moved
across the plain,
endless, relentless, moving toward
the field."*

Homer, Iliad, Book II. Homer loads the simile with sea-words: waves, water,

□ FIELD HARMONY, KABIR (1440-1518)

*"When you were born, you wept
and the world rejoiced.
Live so that when you die,
you rejoice and the world weeps."*

Kabir, doha (Hindi). Birth/death, weeping/rejoicing: the four words form a complete semantic field of transition and reversal. The co-presence of all four activates the whole philosophy before you've consciously registered the pattern. This is tibat (antithesis) and mura'at al-nazir (field

crests, breaking shore. Every word belongs to the same family of restless, unstoppable movement. By the time the battalions appear, the reader has already felt the momentum of ten thousand men through the feeling of ten thousand waves. That semantic coherence is doing work that no single image could. Mura'at al-Nazir in epic form: the entire field used to produce a single effect. Persian poets applied the same technique at the level of the individual ghazal. Homer applied it at the level of the battlefield.

harmony) operating simultaneously: the antitheses (birth/death, weeping/rejoicing) also belong to each other as a coherent group. Kabir's dohas were composed in 15th-century North India and still circulate orally. The same compact field-loading that Hafez applied across a ghazal, Kabir collapsed into two couplets.

Based on Hanjaar-e Goftar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939) & Bahar-e Adab journal (2013).

The Word That Comes Back Every Time

ردیف (Radif)

Persian poetry's most distinctive feature, a phrase repeated identically at the end of every single line. English has no name for this. English poetry avoids it. Music never stopped using it.

Let's talk about repetition, specifically the kind English poetry teachers would mark in red, and Persian poets would consider a mark of mastery.

The radif (ردیف) is a word or group of words that appears identically at the end of each line of a ghazal, after the rhyme word. Not near-identical. Not a variation. The exact same word or phrase, every time. In a ghazal of ten couplets, you might see the word "again", or "what became of you", or "in this city", appearing at the end of every single line. Twenty times. Exactly the same.

Your first instinct might be: that sounds monotonous. That instinct is English conditioning talking. In the Persian tradition, the radif does something completely different. Each time it lands, it means something slightly new because the line before it has changed. The radif is a fixed point. The entire poem orbits it. The repetition doesn't exhaust the word, it deepens it.

Why Repetition Deepens Instead of Boring

Here's the mechanism. When a word repeats in a fixed position, it starts to accumulate meaning. By the fourth or fifth appearance, the listener isn't just hearing the word, they're hearing every previous appearance simultaneously. The word becomes a vessel. The poem fills it over time.

Imagine a poem where every couplet ends with the word "again", and each couplet is about a different kind of return: the lover coming back, the season returning, memory returning, grief returning, the same mistake returning. By the final couplet, "again" doesn't mean any single one of those returns. It means all of them at once. The radif has been stretched to hold everything the poem is about.

Sufis would recognize this as *zikr*, the practice of repeating a divine name until it empties of ordinary meaning and fills with presence. Classical Persian poets did both at once: technical form and spiritual practice in the same structural move. The radif as meditation.

الا يا ايها الساقى ادر كاسا و ناولها
 كه عشق آسان نمود اول ولى افتاد مشكلها
 به بوى ناهى كاخر صبا زان طره بگشايد
 ز تاب جعد مشكينش چه خون افتاد در دلها

Hafez's most famous ghazal. The radif is "-ha" (ها), the Persian plural suffix that becomes the recurring anchor. "Mashkil-ha" (difficulties), "del-ha" (hearts), each couplet introduces something new; the -ha returns like a tide. By the end of the ghazal, that small sound carries the weight of everything the poem has accumulated.

The Closest English Equivalent: The Hook

English poetry doesn't have the radif, but music does. The chorus of a pop song is a radif. The hook in hip-hop is a radif. The repeated line in a folk ballad is a radif. The device is universal in music; it just didn't make it into the English literary tradition, which valued variety at line endings over constancy.

□ RADIF IN MUSIC, AHMAD ZAHIR

"من كه باشم كه بپرسم ز تو حال دل خویش
 من كه باشم كه بگويم غم و احوال دل خویش

□ MUSICAL RADIF, BOB DYLAN

"How many roads must a man walk
 down

تو که خود حال پریشان دلم را می‌دانی
چه بگویم ز پریشانی احوال دل خویش

"Who am I to ask you the state of my own heart / Who am I to tell you the grief and condition of my own heart / You who already know the troubled state of my heart, / What should I say about the disorder of my own heart?", Ahmad Zahir. "Del-e khoysh" (my own heart) functions as a radif across every verse. The phrase gains weight with each return, loaded with more acceptance and resignation by the song's end than it carried at the beginning.

before you call him a man?
The answer, my friend, is blowin' in the wind

The answer is blowin' in the wind

"Blowin' in the Wind." The phrase closes every verse. By the final repetition, it has accumulated the unanswered questions of freedom, war, and human dignity. "Blowin' in the wind" is bigger by the last chorus than it was in the first, the poem has filled the vessel. Same mechanism as the Persian radif. Dylan just called it a chorus.

□ RADIF, FORUGH FARROKHZAD

"تولدی دیگر
من در زهدان جهان زاده شدم
و هر بار از نو زاده می‌شوم
تولدی دیگر، تولدی دیگر"

"Another Birth", Forugh Farrokhzad. The phrase "another birth / tawallodi digar" threads through her entire collection, functioning as a radif at the level of the whole book rather than individual lines. Each poem that uses it adds a new layer: birth as transformation, birth as defiance, birth as grief, birth as self-authorship. By the collection's end, the phrase holds all of it.

□ LITERARY RADIF, EDGAR ALLAN POE

*"Prophet!" said I, 'thing of evil!—
prophet still, if bird or devil!—
Tell me truly, I implore—
Is there—is there balm in Gilead?—
tell me—tell me, I implore!"*
Quoth the Raven, 'Nevermore.'

Poe, "The Raven" (1845). "Nevermore" is a Western radif, placed at the end of every stanza, exactly like the Persian ghazal's radif sits after the rhyme word. And it does exactly what Poe described in "The Philosophy of Composition": by the final stanza, "Nevermore" has accumulated every question in the poem, reunion, hope, relief, and answered them all with the same word. He called it a refrain. The mechanism he describes, a word that deepens with each return, is the same one Persian critics documented a thousand years earlier. Poe arrived at the theory independently and wrote a 3,000-word essay defending it.

□ ANAPHORA-RADIF, WALT WHITMAN

□ **KIGO, JAPANESE HAIKU (BASHO ERA, 17TH CENTURY)**

*"Over the wintry
forest, winds howl in rage
with no leaves to blow."*

Basho, c. 1680s. Japanese haiku uses a system called kigo: a seasonal word that appears in every poem and carries an entire accumulated weight of association. "Wintry forest" in this poem is a kigo for desolation, for the stripped-down, for the world between abundance and renewal. Every haiku reader brings that whole history to the word before the poem has even begun. The kigo doesn't repeat within a poem like the radif, but it functions across thousands of poems the way the radif functions within one: a fixed word that deepens through accumulated use. The Persian tradition concentrated this into the individual ghazal. Japanese poetry spread it across an entire literary culture.

*"Out of the cradle endlessly rocking,
Out of the mocking-bird's throat, the
musical shuttle,
Out of the Ninth-month midnight,
Over the sterile sands and the fields
beyond..."*

Whitman, "Out of the Cradle Endlessly Rocking" (1859). "Out of" functions as a radif at the line's beginning rather than its end — what Persian prosody calls anaphora rather than epiphora — but the mechanism is identical: a phrase that returns at the same position in every line, accumulating weight with each pass. By the time Whitman has cycled through ten "Out of" openings, the phrase carries the whole poem's grief and wonder. He called it "the loose, free form." Persian critics had a classification for it. Both were correct.

□ **QAWWALI RADIF, NUSRAT FATEH ALI KHAN**

*"Koi Kaisay Milta Hai Phool Kaisay
Khilta Hai
Aankh Kaisay Jhukti Hai Saans
Kaisay Rukti Hai
Kaisay Reh Nikalti Hai Kaisay
Baatein Chalti Hai
Shouq Ki Zabaan Kya Hai, Tum Na
Jaan Pao Gay
Shehar Ke Dukandaron, Shehar Ke
Dukandaron"*

"Shehar Ke Dukandaron" (Shopkeepers of the City). "Tum Na Jaan Pao Gay" (you will never know) functions as a radif, falling at the end of every verse across the entire qawwali. Each verse lists something the

□ **CONTEMPORARY RADIF, KENDRICK LAMAR**

*"Promise that you will sing about me
Promise that you will sing about me
...
Promise that you'll sing about me
forever
Promise that you'll sing about me for
— ooh"*

"Sing About Me, I'm Dying of Thirst" (2012). The phrase "Promise that you will sing about me" is a radif — placed identically at the end of each section, accumulating meaning across three completely different perspectives: a gang member dying, a sex worker refusing pity, and Kendrick himself confronting mortality.

"shopkeepers" — people who have transacted everything, commodified everything — cannot understand: how lovers meet, how flowers open, how breath stops, how silence speaks. By the final verse, "you will never know" has accumulated every form of interior experience they've traded away. The phrase hasn't changed. The weight is almost unbearable.

By the outro, it shifts to "forever." Then it cuts off: "for— ooh." The radif is severed mid-word by death, which is the whole argument of the song. Three centuries of Persian poets used the radif to let a word accumulate everything a poem contains. Kendrick uses it to show what happens when the accumulation is interrupted before it can complete.

❑❑ RADIF, MIRZA GHALIB (URDU)

"زاروں خواہشیں ایسی کیں کہ خواہشیں نکلیں
 نکلیں
 نکلیں نکلیں میرا ارمان لیکن پھر بھی کم نکلیں
 ڈر کیوں میرا قاتل کیا رگڑ گا اس کا کیا
 وہ خون جو چشم تر میں عمر بھر یوں دم نکلیں
 دم نکلیں"

"Thousands of desires, each one worth dying for / Many of mine came out, yet still too few came out..." The radif here is nikle (نکلیں, "came out / emerged"), landing at the end of every line after the rhyme. Each couplet pours a different thing through that same fixed word, desires, longings, blood, breath, and by the end nikle holds all of them at once. The word never changes; its weight keeps growing.

❑ ANAPHORA-RADIF + ISHTIQAQ, LUPE FIASCO

کلمہ بہ کلمہ Word-by-word

We who measure the measuring tools of measurers

ما کہ می‌سنجیم - سنجش ابزارهای - سنجندگان

We who pleasure the pleasure tubes of pleasers

ما کہ لذت‌می‌دهیم - لذت لوله‌های - لذت‌جویان

We who lecture at treasured schools of lecturers

ما کہ درس‌می‌دهیم در گرامی مدارس - مدرّسان

We who question the treasured rules of leveragers

ما کہ به پرسش می‌کشیم - گرامی قواعد - بهره‌کشان

"Mural Jr." (2015). Two devices firing at once. We who anchors the front of every line, anaphora, the radif's mirror-image (Persian prosody puts the fixed phrase at the line's end; Whitman and Lupe put it at the front, same mechanism). And the tail of each line, measure / measuring / measurers, is ishtiqaq: three words spun from one root, the agent-suffix "-er(s)" returning like a radif while the root keeps morphing. A fixed frame, refilled four times, each pass heavier than the last. Ghalib's nikle does it at the end; Lupe does it at both ends simultaneously.

□ PHRASE RADIF, BULLEH SHAH (1680-1757)

"بُلّھا کی جاناں میں کون
نہ میں مومن وچ مسیتاں
نہ میں وچ کفر دیاں ریتاں
نہ میں پاکاں وچ پلیتاں
بُلّھا کی جاناں میں کون"

"Bullah, what do I know of who I am / I am not among the faithful in mosques / Nor among the rituals of unbelief / Nor among the clean or the impure / Bullah, what do I know of who I am." Bulleh Shah, 18th-century Punjabi Sufi. Each stanza names a different place the poet is not: among clerics, among ascetics, among Hindus, among Muslims, among the living or the dead. And then the same phrase returns every time: *ki jaana main kaun* (what do I know of who I am). By the final stanza, the phrase has passed through every category and rejected every one. It does not mean the same thing it meant in the first line. The radif has accumulated the entire spiritual journey and come back out the other side holding all of it. Hafez's *mashkil* held difficulties. Ghalib's *nikle* held longing. Bulleh Shah's question holds a complete theology of selfhood, and it sounds exactly the same each time it returns.

□ PHRASE RADIF, TAYLOR SWIFT

"Cause there we are again on that
little town street
You almost ran the red 'cause you
were lookin' over at me
Wind in my hair, I was there
I remember it all too well"

"All Too Well (10 Minute Version)" (2012). "I remember it all too well" is a radif: same phrase, same position, closing every verse while the lines before it change. The song moves through six verses covering the full arc of a relationship, and each time the radif returns it carries the previous stanza with it. By the outro it's not restated once but more than a dozen times, with variations — "Wind in my hair, I was there / Down the stairs, I was there / Sacred prayer, I was there" — where "I was there" becomes a radif inside the radif, each variation a different room of the same memory, the fixed word "there" accumulating every location the song has passed through. Taylor Swift did not study Persian prosody. She arrived at the radif mechanism through grief, which is the same route most poets take. The vessel fills long before the listener realizes what has been happening.

The Monorhyme Alongside the Radif

Alongside the radif, classical Persian poetry in forms like the *qasida* sustains a single rhyme for sometimes a hundred couplets. English readers tend to hear this as constraint. Persian listeners hear it as commitment, the way a blues guitarist sounds completely different over the same 12-bar progression every

time, or the way a jazz musician can take a standard and make it entirely their own.

در ازل پرتو حُسنَت ز تجلّی دم زد"
عشق پیدا شد و آتش به همه عالم زد
عقل می خواست کز آن شعله چراغ افروزد
"برق غیرت بزد و دودمان عالم زد"

Hafez, "In eternity, the radiance of Your beauty breathed forth in revelation / Love appeared, and set fire to the whole world / Reason wanted to light a lamp from that flame / But the lightning of jealousy struck and burned the world's household." The radif structure of this ghazal mirrors its theological content: the repeated return to the same ending word enacts the cyclical nature of divine emanation the poem is describing. Form and meaning are not separate.

Try this listening experiment: Next time a song's final chorus hits differently than the first one, same words, more weight, that's the radif mechanism. The song has filled the phrase with everything that came before it. Hafez's readers felt exactly this in the maqta (final couplet) of a ghazal. The device is older than any of us, and it still works every time.

Based on Hanjaar-e Goftar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939) & Bahar-e Adab journal (2013).

Every Era Sounds Like Something

سبک (Sabk)

Persian literary history has three great styles across a thousand years. English has its own. Ahmad Zahir vs. Farhad Darya. The Romantics vs. the Metaphysicals. Same argument, every generation.

Every era writes differently, not just in content, but in texture. The density of the imagery. How abstract or concrete the language is. The relationship between sound and sense. The emotional temperature of the whole thing. Persian criticism has a word for this: sab'k (سبک), style.

The Persian tradition maps its history through three dominant styles. English literary history does something similar with different names. Put them next to each other and you see what style actually is, not just aesthetics, but a whole philosophy of what language is for.

Style One: Khorasani, Direct, Clear, Energetic (9th-12th Century)

Khorasan, spanning modern Iran, Afghanistan, and Central Asia, gave Persian poetry its first major flowering. The Khorasani style is direct, concrete, energetic. The imagery is drawn from the physical world: mountains, horses, wine, roses, the hunt. The meters are vigorous. The vocabulary is relatively plain. When a hero is brave, the poet says so with a strong image and moves on, no layers of mystical meaning, no philosophical scaffolding.

□ KHORASANI, RUDAKI (C. 940 CE)

"بوی جوی مولیان آید همی
یاد یار مهربان آید همی"

□ ENGLISH PARALLEL, ANGLO-SAXON / EARLY ENGLISH

"The sea surged, the wave beat shore
The world's candle shone, the wind
was still"

ریگ آموی و درشتی راه او
زیر پایم پرنیان آید همی"

"The scent of the Moliyan stream keeps coming / The memory of a kind friend keeps coming / The sand of the Amu and the roughness of its road / Feels like silk under my feet.", Rudaki, the oldest surviving major Persian poem. Direct sensory imagery, scent, memory, texture underfoot. No mystical allegory, no conceptual density. The clarity IS the beauty. Feel the longing for home in the sand and the scent.

*He saw the headlands gleam, the
cliffs grow bright
And steered his ship toward where
the light was spilt"*

Old English poetic tradition (Beowulf-era). Same Khorasani directness, compound images, physical world as emotional register, no abstraction. "World's candle" for the sun: two concrete nouns, one strong image, nothing hidden. These two traditions, separated by thousands of miles, landed on the same aesthetic instinct independently.

Style Two: 'Araqi, Layered, Spiritual, Doubly-Encoded (12th-15th Century)

This is the era most Western readers know: Rumi, Sa'di, Hafez. The imagery is still there, but now it carries double weight. Wine is wine AND divine ecstasy. The garden is a garden AND paradise AND the beloved's face. The poetry becomes doubly-encoded: love poetry on the surface, spiritual poetry underneath. Both readings are valid. That doubleness IS the style.

□ 'ARAQI, HAFEZ (14TH CENTURY)

"دلم جز مهر مه رویان طریقی بر نمی‌گیرد
ز هر در می‌زنم چون مهر بر لب قفل می‌گیرد
خدایا آن که رخسارش بیست راه عقل و دین
ببند این زلف دامان‌گیر را بگشا دلم"

"My heart takes no path other than the love of moon-faced ones / From every door I try, the lock falls silent like a seal on lips. / O God, the one whose face blocked the path of reason and religion / Bind up those hem-catching curls and open my heart." Multiple simultaneous layers: literal romantic frustration, spiritual seeking, and

□ ENGLISH PARALLEL, METAPHYSICAL POETS (17TH CENTURY)

*"Mark but this flea, and mark in this,
How little that which thou deny'st
me is;
It sucked me first, and now sucks
thee,
And in this flea our two bloods
mingled be"*

John Donne. The Metaphysical conceit works exactly like 'Araqi double-coding: a mundane, almost absurd vehicle (a flea) carries enormous erotic and philosophical

a joke about desire blocking reason. All three active at once. That's the 'Araqi style in practice.

freight. You track two registers simultaneously, what he's literally saying and what he actually means. The style demands both at once. It's disconcerting and delicious in exactly the same way as Hafez.

Style Three: Hindi, Dense, Strange, Compressed (16th-18th Century)

When the Mughal empire brought Persian poets to India, something interesting happened. Cut off from the Persian heartland, in dialogue with Sanskrit aesthetics, the style changed. The Sab'k-e Hindi is characterized by intellectual density, unusual conceits, and a preference for the surprising over the beautiful. Images get stranger, more compressed, more conceptual.

Bedil (Mirza Abdul Qadir Bedil, 1644–1720), born in what is now Uttar Pradesh, hugely influential in Afghanistan, is the supreme example. His poetry can be almost impenetrable on first read, then flash open with sudden clarity. It's the Persian equivalent of Gerard Manley Hopkins: concentrated, difficult, grammatically unusual. When it works, it's unforgettable.

□□ HINDI STYLE, BEDIL (DARI/PERSIAN)

"نه ما دانیم و نه ایشان که ما را کی رها کردند
در این وحشت سرا دل‌های ما دیوانه‌وار آمد
نه از خود بود و نه از غیر بود این آمدن ما
همان مهمان‌نوازی بود که دعوت داشت"

"Neither we know, nor they, when they released us / In this wilderness our hearts arrived like madmen / Our coming was neither from ourselves nor from another, / It was only a hospitality that had issued an invitation." Dense, questioning, existential. The "they" who released us is ambiguous (God? fate? parents?). The "wilderness" is both the literal world and an interior state.

□ ENGLISH PARALLEL, GERARD MANLEY HOPKINS

*"I am soft sift
In an hourglass, at the wall
Fast, but mined with a motion, a
drift,
And it crowds and it combs to the
fall"*

Hopkins, "The Wreck of the Deutschland." Grammatically strange, conceptually dense, the self as sand, the hourglass as life, the falling as inevitability. The difficulty is the point: the resistance of the language mirrors the resistance of the

Everything compressed to near-breaking.
Sab'k-e Hindi.

subject matter. Hopkins and Bedil never encountered each other's work. They arrived at the same aesthetic instinct from different corners of a century.

The Style Debate in Afghan Music

Style history isn't just literary, it's alive in how contemporary Afghan music sounds. Two artists make the contrast vivid:

□ 'ARAQI STYLE, AHMAD ZAHIR (1946-1979)

"مه رويا، مه رويا، کجا رفتی؟
دل من، دل من، چرا رفتی؟
نه گفتم، نه پرسیدی، نه برگشتی
کجا رفتی که من بی تو نتوانم"

"O moon-faced one, where did you go? / My heart, my heart, why did you leave? / You didn't say, didn't ask, didn't return / Where did you go that I cannot be without you?", Ahmad Zahir drew directly on classical 'Araqi imagery (the moon-faced beloved, the suffering heart) but delivered it through warm, Western-influenced vocal arrangements. Classically coded, emotionally direct, universally beloved across generations.

□ CONTEMPORARY, FARHAD DARYA (1962-)

"آزادی، آزادی
افغانستان، وطنم
سبزه و کوه و دشت و دریای تو
هر گوشه‌ی تو باغ و گلستان"

"Freedom, freedom / Afghanistan, my homeland / Your greenery, mountains, plains and rivers / Every corner of you is a garden and rose-meadow.", Farhad Darya's post-war work trades classical double-coded imagery for direct address: freedom, homeland, resilience. The figurative scaffolding is lighter; the political urgency is higher. A move from 'Araqi elaborateness toward Khorasani directness, made necessary by the times.

*"We are such stuff as dreams are made on,
and our little life
is rounded with a sleep."*

Shakespeare, *The Tempest*, late style. No Badi' decoration, no elaborated simile. Just the compressed metaphor (life as dream, death as sleep surrounding it) delivered with devastating simplicity. Shakespeare's late style and late Bedil's work move in

the same direction: the ornament burns away, and only the essential image remains. The most sophisticated thing both traditions do is eventually learn to say less.

Sab'k-e Hindi in Hip-Hop

The same conditions that produced Sab'k-e Hindi, displacement, dialogue with an alien aesthetic, a tradition cut off from its source and forced to reinvent itself, produced something in hip-hop that looks remarkably similar. Dense, self-referential, difficult on first listen, then suddenly clear.

□□ HINDI STYLE, BEDIL

"نه ما دانيم و نه ايشان که ما را کی رها کردند
در این وحشت سرا دل‌های ما دیوانه‌وار آمد
نه از خود بود و نه از غیر بود این آمدن ما
همان مهمان‌نوازی بود که دعوت داشت"

"Neither we know, nor they, when they released us / In this wilderness our hearts arrived like madmen / Our coming was neither from ourselves nor from another, / It was only a hospitality that had issued an invitation." The existential question (who released us? who invited us?) is never answered. The ambiguity is the meaning. Bedil's Persian is far from the Khorasani homeland — in Mughal India, speaking to Sanskrit aesthetics, the style got stranger, denser, more difficult. That difficulty is the record of the displacement.

□ CONTEMPORARY HINDI STYLE, LUPE FIASCO

کلمه به کلمه *Word-by-word*

Most of what we know as art is the projection of a faith

بیشتر - آنچه ما می‌شناسیم به عنوان هنر - - فراق‌کنی -
یک ایمان

The product of a Pontiff or the election of a saint

- فرآورده - یک پاپ یا - برگزیدن - یک قدیس

A gift from the read for the digestion of the can't

یک هدیه از - باسوادان برای - هضم - - ناتوانان

A visual garnish for the confessions of the frank

یک بصري چاشنی برای - اعترافات - - روراستان

Displays of physical carnage make connections to the ranks

نمایش‌های - جسمانی کشتار می‌سازند پیوند با -
صفوف

"Ms. Mural" (2015). Dense, rhyme-driven, internally consistent but almost impossible to paraphrase, every line is the same scaffold (the X of a/the Y) refilled with a stranger pair each time. The painter-patron

dialogue carries an argument about art, faith, and commodification that keeps slipping out of reach and snapping back into focus. This is the engine of Sab'k-e Hindi: ma'ni-afarini, "meaning-creation," prizing the surprising conceit over the beautiful one. And on "Mural Jr." Lupe names the device while doing it, "That's rather meta-poetic, and just to acknowledge that / As an extra exhibit to what's already within it", the same self-aware density Bedil's readers wrestled with. Lupe works in a tradition (American hip-hop) far from its oral roots, rapping about painting until painting becomes a frame for everything else. The displacement that made Bedil strange is making Lupe strange. The conditions rhyme even if the centuries don't.

Based on Hanjaar-e Goftar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939) & Bahar-e Adab journal (2013).

The Reason Some Lines Just Feel Right

فصاحت (Fasahat)

Fasahat, eloquence, is the foundation. Before any of the clever devices, there's this: language that sounds right, fits the moment, and carries no dead weight. Both traditions agree on the rules, even when they disagree on everything else.

We've covered the flashy stuff, simile, metaphor, double meaning, wordplay, the radif. All of it only works if the basic language underneath is right. That basic rightness has a name in Persian: fasahat (فصاحت).

Fasahat means eloquence, but not showy eloquence. It means language that is clear, fitting, appropriate, and pleasant to say and hear. Taqavi's Hanjaar-e Gofar opens with fasahat because without it, all the Bayan and Badi' in the world is just expensive noise. The foundation has to be solid before the architecture can be beautiful.

And here's the thing: the rules both traditions lay down for fasahat are almost identical. They arrived at them independently. Because the problems fasahat solves are universal, they're not Persian problems or English problems, they're human problems with language.

Rule One: If It's Hard to Say, Rewrite It

Both Persian and English rhetoric flag the same problem: putting sounds next to each other that produce a harsh, difficult result. In Persian this is called tanafur-e huruf (تنافر حروف), the friction of letters. Dental consonants clustered together, aspirates colliding, vowels stopping and starting awkwardly. The result is a line that stumbles in the mouth.

English composition handbooks say the same thing. "The student's strengths stretched across several sessions", technically correct, practically a tongue-twister. Both traditions have the same practical test: read it out loud. If your mouth struggles, your reader's ear will too.

□ GOOD SOUND, RUMI

"بشنو این نی چون شکایت می‌کند
از جدایی‌ها حکایت می‌کند
کز نیستان تا مرا بیریده‌اند
از نفیرم مرد و زن نالیده‌اند"

"Listen to the reed, how it complains /
From separations it tells its tales / Since
they cut me from the reed bed / Every man
and woman has mourned alongside me."
Read this aloud in Persian: the nasal "n"
sounds, the soft "sh," the flowing "m", the
sound enacts what the words describe. The
reed's voice IS the music of the line.
Fasahat: when sound and meaning fuse.

□ GOOD SOUND, KEATS

*"Season of mists and mellow
fruitfulness,
Close bosom-friend of the maturing
sun;
Conspiring with him how to load and
bless
With fruit the vines that round the
thatch-eves run"*

Keats, "To Autumn." The "m" and "f"
alliteration, the long vowels, the softness of
"mellow" and "fruitfulness", it's physically
pleasant to say. Keats reportedly composed
while walking and reciting, not sitting and
writing. He knew the mouth was the judge,
not the eye.

Rule Two: Use Words That Belong in the Room

In Persian, this is gharabat-e lughat (غرابت لغات), the strangeness of vocabulary. Don't use foreign words that haven't been naturalized, archaic words no one knows, or technical terms dropped without context into emotional writing. The word might be accurate; it still doesn't belong.

In English: register mismatch. Using corporate jargon in a love poem. Medical terminology in a lullaby. Slang in a legal argument. The word is correct; the room is wrong.

□□ RIGHT WORD, RIGHT ROOM, HAFEZ

□ RIGHT WORD, RIGHT ROOM, WALT WHITMAN

"یک قدح می باید و دیوانگی
کشتن آن پیر عقل خود بینی
پیر ما گفت خطا بر قلم صنع نرفت
آفرین بر نظر پاک خطاپوشش باد"

"One cup of wine is needed, and madness /
To kill that old, self-seeing reason. / Our
elder said: no error passed through the pen
of creation, / Bless his pure gaze that
covers up faults." Every word is common,
clear, and carries weight. "Old" and "self-
seeing" do double work in three syllables,
describing reason as decrepit AND
narcissistic. No foreign insertions, no
jargon. The vocabulary fits the room
exactly.

"Do I contradict myself?
Very well then I contradict myself,
(I am large, I contain multitudes.)"

Whitman, "Song of Myself" (1855).
Democratic American vernacular mixed
with philosophical scope: "large" is
ordinary, "multitudes" is grand, and the
combination works because Whitman built
the whole poem in that register, plain
speech doing the work of epic. The
parenthesis at the end, repeating the line
after the argument, is maqam: this is a
poem about self and contradiction, so the
form contradicts itself. Every word is in the
right room, and the room was designed so
that the contradiction fits.

Rule Three: Cut the Filler

Hashw (حشو) is filler, words added to a line to complete the meter or fill the syllable count that don't add meaning. One of the classic sins of Persian verse, catalogued by Taqavi as a mark of weakness. "A verse containing hashw is like a body with unnecessary limbs: technically complete, but actually deformed."

English composition: padding. "In order to," "it is important to note that," "for all intents and purposes." Writing that reaches the word count without earning it. Every writing teacher you've ever had said this. Persian critics were saying it in the 10th century.

× ZERO FILLER, OMAR KHAYYAM

"یک قدح می باید و دیوانگی
کشتن آن پیر عقل خود بینی
می خور که هر کی نخورد باده پشیمان شود
در آخر که نه کس ماند نه کاشانه"

"One cup of wine is needed and madness /
To kill that old self-seeing reason / Drink,

× ZERO FILLER, HENRY DAVID
THOREAU

"I went to the woods because I
wished to live deliberately,
to front only the essential facts of
life,
and see if I could not learn what it

for whoever doesn't drink wine will regret it / In the end, neither anyone remains nor any home." Khayyam. Every word is load-bearing. "Old" and "self-seeing" describe reason as both decrepit and narcissistic in the same breath. The final line, "neither anyone nor any home", compresses the whole human condition into six words.

*had to teach,
and not, when I came to die, discover
that I had not lived."*

Thoreau, *Walden* (1854). Every word earns its place. "Deliberately" does the work of three sentences. "Front" (to face directly, to meet head-on) is one syllable carrying confrontation and intention. "Discover that I had not lived" at the end compresses a whole philosophy of regret into seven words. No hashw. The rhythm holds because nothing could be removed without loss. Khayyam and Thoreau were both asking the same question from opposite sides of the world: if you could live deliberately, would you? Both answered in prose that couldn't afford to waste a word.

Rule Four: Match the Occasion

The concept of maqam (مقام), situational appropriateness, is both a Ma'ani principle and a fasahat requirement. A technically perfect line in the wrong context is still a failure of eloquence. Classical Persian court poetry had elaborate conventions about which poems fit which occasions: qasidas for royal praise, ghazals for intimate gatherings, marsiyya for mourning. Being out of register was a craft failure, not just a social one.

□□ MAQAM, IQBAL AT THE RIGHT MOMENT

"خودی کو کر بلند اتنا کہ / ہر تقدیر سے پہلے
خدا بند سے خود پوچھے، بتا تیری رضا کیا ہے
ستاروں سے آگے جاں اور بھی ہیں
ابھی عشق کے امتحاں اور بھی ہیں"

"Raise yourself so high that before each decree of fate / God Himself asks you: tell me, what is your will? / Beyond the stars there are other worlds / There are still

□ MAQAM, SHAKESPEARE, DIFFERENT ROOMS

*"Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend
me your ears;
I come to bury Caesar, not to praise
him.
The evil that men do lives after them;
The good is oft interred with their
bones."*

more trials of love ahead.", Iqbal writing for a Muslim community at a particular political and historical moment. These lines were recited at independence movements, memorized by children, sung at public gatherings. The maqam, the occasion, shaped the directness, the urgency, the grandiosity. The same content written for a private notebook would need a different register.

Mark Antony's funeral oration, Julius Caesar. This is maqam in English: a public speech in a public moment, and Shakespeare gives it the public register it requires, direct address, short sentences, rhetorical rhythm, irony that the crowd can follow. Compare it to Hamlet's soliloquy: same playwright, completely different occasion, completely different register. That flexibility IS the craft.

"The goal of all these rules, sound, vocabulary, filler, occasion, is ultimately to make the language disappear. The most eloquent writing is the kind where you forget you're reading. You feel you're experiencing directly."

The paradox at the heart of both traditions: all these rules exist so that, eventually, you don't notice any of them. When a verse is perfectly constructed, the construction disappears. You just feel the thing the verse is about. That's fasahat at its summit: language that earns its own absence.

Breaking One Rule to Keep the Deeper One

Fasahat has an opposite, and a name for it: ta'qid (تعقيد), willful obscurity, the line so tangled the reader can't get through it. Classical critics list it as a failure. But there's a paradox the tradition itself half-admits: Sab'k-e Hindi made controlled difficulty a virtue. Bedil is hard on purpose. The trick is that the difficulty must never come from hashw (filler), it has to come from compression. Break the clarity rule, but obey the no-waste rule absolutely. Lupe Fiasco's "Mural" is the clearest modern case of exactly this bargain.

□□ PRODUCTIVE TA'QID, BEDIL (DARI)

□ TA'QID + ZERO HASHW, LUPE FIASCO

کلمه به کلمه Word-by-word

"نه ما دانيم و نه ايشان که ما را کی رها کردند
در این وحشت سرا دل‌های ما دیوانه‌وار آمد
نه از خود بود و نه از غیر بود این آمدن ما
همان مهمان‌نوازی بود که دعوت داشت"

"Neither we know, nor they, when they released us / In this wilderness our hearts arrived like madmen / Our coming was neither from ourselves nor another, / It was only a hospitality that had issued an invitation." Bedil is deliberately hard, the "they," the "release," the "invitation" are all left unresolved. But run the test: try to cut a single word. You can't. The difficulty is pure compression, not padding. That's ta'qid as craft, not as failure.

You gotta treat your vocal chords like it's a fortress

تو باید رفتار کنی - صوتی تارهای مثل - یک قلعه

And treat every single one of your words like reinforcements

و رفتار کن هر یکایک - - - کلمات مثل نیروهای کمکی

"Mural" (2015). An eight-minute verse with no hook and no chorus, the most obscure thing in his catalogue, and yet not one syllable is filler. Lupe even states the fasahat ethic out loud mid-song: guard the voice like a fortress, treat each word like a military reinforcement, something deployed for a reason, never dead weight. He breaks the surface rule of fasahat (be clear) while obeying its deepest rule (waste nothing). Exactly Bedil's bargain: the difficulty is earned because the economy underneath it is total.

Fasahat Without Borders

Persian critics formalized these rules in the 9th century. But the underlying problem, how do you make language disappear into experience, is one every tradition solved independently. The names change. The conclusions don't.

□ SOUND AND SENSE, HORACE (65-8 BCE)

*"Dum loquimur, fugerit invida
aetas: carpe diem, quam minimum
credula postero."*

"While we speak, envious time will have fled: seize the day, trust as little as possible in tomorrow." Horace, Odes I.11. The Latin sound is doing fasahat work: "fugerit" (will have fled) comes in the middle of the sentence, at the moment the thing it

□ ZERO FILLER, THIRUVALLUVAR (C. 1ST CENTURY BCE-CE)

*"The greatness of a man who has
conquered himself
exceeds the greatness of a man who
has conquered the world."*

Thiruvalluvar, Tirukkural, Book I (Tamil). Each of the 1,330 Kural couplets is exactly two lines. No exceptions. The formal constraint forces every word to earn its place — the Tamil tradition made anti-

describes happens — the line enacts its meaning. "Carpe diem" is two syllables. It contains everything the next paragraph would say. No hashw. Horace composed his odes as slowly and deliberately as any Persian ghazal. Both traditions agreed: the poem should sound like it couldn't be shorter.

hashw a structural requirement rather than an aspiration. This couplet contains a tibiaq (self vs. world), a complete argument, and a reversal of expected value (inner over outer). Two lines. Nothing extra. Taqavi called this kind of economy "the most advanced fasahat": when the constraint and the content become the same thing.

Based on Hanjaar-e Goftar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939) & Bahar-e Adab journal (2013).

From Kabul to Compton

(Sonnat-e Zendeه) سنت زنده

The tradition didn't die. It changed clothes. From the courts of Khorasan to Tehran apartments to diaspora bedrooms to YouTube channels, the same tools, the same hunger, different decades.

One thing that makes Persian and Dari literary history different from, say, Latin poetry is that it never became a dead tradition. Ovid is studied in classrooms as a curiosity. But Hafez, who died in 1390, is still consulted as an oracle by families across Iran, Afghanistan, Tajikistan, and the diaspora. His Divan sits next to the Quran in many homes. You open it at random for guidance on a decision. That's not academic. That's a living relationship with a 600-year-old book.

This section looks at how the classical tradition continues, in Afghan and Iranian music, in Urdu poetry, in diaspora writing, in Persian hip-hop, and in the unexpected places where tashbih and radif and kinaya show up without their classical names.

Ahmad Zahir, The Tradition in a Single Voice

Ahmad Zahir (1946–1979) is the most important figure for understanding how classical Persian poetics survived into the modern era in Afghanistan. He's sometimes called "the Afghan Elvis," but that undersells him. He was more like a synthesis of Elvis and Bob Dylan, a popular entertainer who was also a serious artist, drawing on classical literary material to speak to a country living through rapid change and approaching catastrophe.

□ AHMAD ZAHIR, CLASSICAL IMAGERY,
MODERN DELIVERY

□ PARALLEL, BOB MARLEY

"No woman no cry
I remember when we used to sit

"دلم گرفته از این شهر پر ملال و غبار
کجاست آن رفیق همدرد و آن دیار
دیگر نه آن وطن است و نه آن یار
نه آن چراغ روشن و نه آن بهار"

"My heart is heavy in this sad, dusty city / Where is that understanding friend, that homeland / There is no longer that homeland, nor that friend / Neither that bright light nor that spring.", Zahir set classical ghazal language to Western orchestration and sometimes Latin rhythms. The images, the dusty city, the lost companion, the extinguished light, are pure Khorasani. The delivery was 1970s pop. He died aged 33, one year before the Soviet invasion. His music still plays at every Afghan gathering in every city in the world.

*in the government yard in
Trenchtown
observing the hypocrites
as they would mingle with the good
people we meet"*

Marley, 1974. The same move as Zahir: classical folk imagery (the yard, the community, the gathering) delivered through contemporary popular form. Both artists used their respective folk-poetic traditions to speak about displacement and loss to audiences who were living through exactly that. The form is different. The function is identical.

Forugh Farrokhzad, Breaking the Form to Save It

Forugh Farrokhzad (1935–1967) did something radical: she used the classical tools, tashbih, isti'ara, kinaya, to write about subjects the tradition had kept off the table. Female desire. The body as lived experience. Grief as a specific, physical thing. Refusal of the roles assigned to women.

□□ **FORUGH FARROKHZAD, TAWALLODI DIGAR (1964)**

"در شبی که تو از آن نخواهی آمد
درد دارم از تو، از تو درد دارم
دست‌هایم را دراز می‌کنم
دستی نیست، دستی نیست، دستی نیست"

"In a night from which you will not come / I hurt from you, I hurt from you / I reach out my hands, / There is no hand, no hand, no hand.", Farrokhzad. The radif-like repetition ("I hurt from you," "no hand") is

□ **WARSAN SHIRE (SOMALI-BRITISH)**

*"You are a horse running alone
and he tries to tame you
compares you to an impossible
highway
to a burning house
says you are blinding him
that he could never leave you"*

Warsan Shire, the Somali-British poet who wrote much of Beyoncé's Lemonade. Open-ended isti'ara: woman as horse, as

classical in its form. The content, a woman's specific, embodied grief, the physical reaching and finding nothing, was revolutionary in Persian literature at the time. She inherited the whole toolkit and aimed it somewhere new.

highway, as burning house. The vehicle stacks up without the ground being stated. Each image says something different about the same impossible dynamic. Farrokhzad and Shire are working in the same tradition, classical tools, subjects the tradition originally excluded.

Iqbal, When a Poem Becomes a Political Manifesto

Allama Iqbal (1877–1938), Pakistan's national poet, the thinker who first articulated the concept of a Muslim homeland in South Asia, used Urdu and Persian poetry as political philosophy. He took the Sufi concept of khudi (selfhood) and turned it into an argument for collective self-determination.

خودی کو کر بلند اتنا کہ ہر تقدیر سے پہلے
خدا بندہ سے خود پوچھے، بتا تیری رضا کیا ہے
ستاروں سے آگے جاؤں اور بھی ہیں
ابھی عشق کے امتحان اور بھی ہیں

"Raise yourself so high that before each decree of fate / God Himself asks you: tell me, what is your will? / Beyond the stars there are other worlds / There are still more trials of love ahead.", Iqbal. Fasahat (clear, no filler), tibatq (fate vs. will), and a bold Ma'ani move in the second line: the interrogative inverts the expected subject of divine authority. God asks; the human answers. These lines were memorized by children in Pakistani schools for generations and recited at independence rallies. The classical Persian-Urdu tradition of the poem as public, collective utterance, carried into the 20th century.

Persian Hip-Hop, Underground and Alive

Persian-language hip-hop is one of the most interesting cultural spaces of the last 25 years. Artists in Iran working under censorship, in the diaspora

working between languages, they brought the classical Persian poetic tradition into a form the tradition's gatekeepers didn't recognize. And in doing so, they kept it alive.

□ HICHKAS, PERSIAN RAP (TEHRAN)

"ما آینه‌ی جامعه‌ایم
می‌گیم اون چیزی که همه می‌دونن
ولی کسی جرئت نداره بگه
این موزیک صدای اون‌هایی‌ه که صدا ندارن"

"We are the mirror of society / We say what everyone knows / But no one has the courage to say / This music is the voice of those who have no voice.", Hichkas, often called the godfather of Persian rap. The isti'ara (rap artist as mirror) is classical. The application, using poetry as documentation of what official culture suppresses, is the same thing Hafez was doing with wine. The kinaya just moved from the tavern to the street.

□ KENDRICK LAMAR, SAME MIRROR

*"I come from a generation of pain
These are the stories I've told again
and again
The ones that kept us up at night
And woke us up before light"*

Kendrick's central project, the rapper as witness and vessel for a community's experience, mirrors the Persian tradition where the poet is a container for collective memory and language. The artist who speaks what everyone knows but no one can officially say. Hichkas and Kendrick are doing the same job in different cities, under different pressures, with different accents.

Sometimes the connection runs deeper than imagery or allusion. Sometimes the source text itself shows up.

□ SURAH AN-NAS (THE 114TH CHAPTER)

"قُلْ أَعُوذُ بِرَبِّ النَّاسِ
مَلِكِ النَّاسِ
إِلَهِ النَّاسِ
مِنْ شَرِّ الْوَسْوَاسِ الْخَنَّاسِ
الَّذِي يُوَسْوِسُ فِي صُدُورِ النَّاسِ
مِنَ الْجِنَّةِ وَالنَّاسِ"

"Say: I seek refuge in the Lord of mankind / The King of mankind / The God of mankind / From the evil of the retreating whisperer / Who whispers in the breasts of mankind / From among the jinn and mankind." The Surah is itself a study in

□ LUPE FIASCO, "KING NAS" — OUTRO

*"Qul a'uudhi bi rabbin naas
Malikin naas, Ilaahin naas
Min sharriil wawaasil khannas
Alladhee yuwaswisu fee suduurin
naas
Minal Jinnati wa naas"*

The song title is three things at once: King NAS (the rapper), nas (Arabic: mankind, the word the Surah is named for), and Surah An-Nas itself. The rap ends with the Surah recited verbatim in transliterated Arabic — no translation offered, no explanation given. Not an allusion. Not

radif: al-nas (mankind) falls at the end of five of six verses, accumulating weight — Lord of people, King of people, God of people, breasts of people, from among people. The triple address (Rabb/Malik/Ilah) builds from guardian to sovereign to divine. And the closing tibiaq: the threat comes from two directions at once, jinn and mankind, the unseen and the visible. In classical Arabic rhetoric, this chapter's compactness and its interlocking devices have been studied for over a millennium as a model of inimitability (i'jaz al-Quran). Six verses. Every device present.

borrowed imagery. The source text itself, 1400 years old, spoken aloud at the end of a Chicago rap about the ghetto, survival, and becoming a man. The tradition doesn't need ceremony to survive. It shows up when it's needed, and it sounds exactly the same as it always did.

Qawwali, The Tradition That Never Stopped

While Persian literature's survival in Afghanistan and Iran is partly a story of adaptation and resistance, in South Asia it never required rescue. Qawwali, the Sufi devotional form that draws on Rumi, Hafez, Amir Khusrow, and the whole classical tradition, has been performed continuously for 700 years. It isn't a revival. It never died.

□ NUSRAT FATEH ALI KHAN, QAWWALI

*"Wasl Ka Sukoon Kya Hai, Hijr Ka Junoon Kya Hai
Husn Ka Fusoon Kya Hai, Ishq Ke Daroon Kya Hai
Tum Mareez-E-Danai Maslihat Ke Shaydai
Raah-E-Gumrahan Kya Hai, Tum Na Jaan Pao Gay
Shehar Ke Dukandaron, Shehar Ke Dukandaron"*

"What is the peace of union, what is the madness of separation / What is the enchantment of beauty, what is the interior

□ AR RAHMAN, KUN FAYA KUN

*"Rangreza, rangreza
Kun fayakun, kun fayakun fayakun
Jab kahin pe kuch nahi, bhi nahi tha
Wahi tha, wahi tha, wahi tha"*

"Rangreza" (the divine colorist, the one who dyes existence). "Kun fayakun" — "Be, and it is" — the Quranic verse of creation (36:82). "When nowhere was anything, not even nothing — He was there." AR Rahman's "Kun Faya Kun" (from Rockstar, 2011) is Sufi isti'ara in a film soundtrack: God as rangreza (a dyer of cloth) is an implied metaphor — the vehicle (a craftsman who colors things) present, the

of love / You who are sick with knowledge,
devoted to calculation / What is the path of
the lost — you will never know /
Shopkeepers of the city, shopkeepers of the
city." Nusrat's "Shehar Ke Dukandaron"
draws on tibiaq (union/separation, peace/
madness) and kinaya (shopkeepers as
people who have commodified everything)
from the classical toolkit, delivered in a
form that hasn't changed in structure since
the 13th century. The ghazal's tools inside
the qawwali's form, and both reaching
back to the same Persian source.

tenor (divine creation) implied. And the
radif-like repetition of "Kun fayakun"
across the whole track deepens it with
each pass. The classical device, the Sufi
theology, the qawwali structure, all of it
reaching seven hundred years back and
sounding completely contemporary.

The Diaspora Poem, Where It All Comes Together

Some of the most alive poetry right now lives in the collision zone, Afghan, Iranian, Pakistani, and Somali writers who grew up with two languages, two poetic traditions, two sets of tools. They're not choosing between them. They're using both simultaneously.

□ KAVEH AKBAR (IRANIAN-AMERICAN)

*"I am trying to understand the gift of
thirst.
Which is to say: I am trying to
understand
why I want what I want. Why I reach
into the dark and pull out only more
dark."*

Kaveh Akbar, Pilgrim Bell. The Sufi vocabulary of thirst and longing, central to Persian Bayan, delivered through contemporary American confessional poetry. "Reaching into the dark and pulling out more dark" is an isti'ara-ye makniyya (implied metaphor) that Bedil would recognize immediately. Akbar didn't learn

□ FARHAD DARYA, DIASPORA VOICE

آزادی، آزادی
من از آزادی می‌خوانم
وطنم کوه‌های سر به فلک
صدایم را به آن‌ها می‌رسانم

"Freedom, freedom / I sing of freedom / My homeland: mountains reaching to the sky / I send my voice to them.", Farhad Darya writing and singing from exile. The radif ("freedom"), the direct address, the physical image of mountains as an audience, all classical devices. The context, a singer in exile reaching toward a homeland he can't return to, makes the devices do what they've always been designed to do: carry what can't be said directly.

it from Bedil. He learned it from being Iranian and American and both at once.

The End, and the Maqta

In a ghazal, the final couplet is called the maqta (مقطع). The poet names themselves, addresses themselves, sometimes wryly, sometimes tenderly. The whole poem has led here. The radif lands one final time, carrying everything it's accumulated across the whole ghazal.

What this site has tried to show is that the tools of beautiful language, simile, metaphor, ornament, clarity, style, the management of repetition, are human tools. They appear wherever people decide that words are for something more than information. For truth-telling that exceeds what information can carry. For making the listener feel what can't be stated. For making language earn its own disappearance into experience.

The tradition is alive because the hunger is alive. People will keep making this kind of language as long as they need to say things that resist direct saying. That's not a prediction. It's the oldest fact in literary history.

حافظ در کنج فقر و خلوت شب
ورد وظیفه‌ی خویش بخوان و بشادباش
که آن دم صبح نفس کز تو دانست
نه از بهر آن گفت که غمگین شوی

"Hafez, in the corner of poverty and the solitude of night / Recite your prayers and be joyful / For that breath of morning that knew you / Did not tell you this so that you would grieve.", Hafez's own maqta: he names himself, gives himself permission to be happy in impossible circumstances, and closes the whole ghazal with that. The tradition ends as it began, one person, one voice, language doing everything it can.

Where to Go From Here

Read: Hafez's Divan (Shahriar Shahriari's translation is free online). Rumi's Masnavi (Coleman Barks, or Arberry for fidelity). Ghalib's Urdu ghazals (any edition with facing translation). Forugh Farrokhzad's Another Birth. Iqbal's Bang-e-Dra. Kaveh Akbar's Pilgrim Bell. Listen: Ahmad Zahir (start with "Mast Mast" and "Ey Del"). Shahram Nazeri (classical Persian vocal, breathtaking). Ustad Mahwash (Afghan classical vocal). Hichkas (Persian hip-hop). Farhad Darya. Googoosh (Iranian pop, active since the 1960s). Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan (start with "Shehar Ke Dukandaron" and "Mustt Mustt"). AR Rahman's "Kun Faya Kun." Lupe Fiasco's Tetsuo & Youth (for what Sab'k-e Hindi sounds like in English). Watch: A Separation (Farhadi, 2011), for how everyday Persian speech uses these rhetorical tools constantly, without ceremony. Kabul Transit (2006 documentary), for the city that produced Ahmad Zahir and still carries his voice.

Based on Hanjaar-e Goftar by Nasrollah Taqavi (1939) & Bahar-e Adab journal (2013).